Twice-Born

Chapter 1

A palace servant came home with news he wasn't meant to hear. That evening, his wife repeated it to her friends around the well. The next morning, a fruit merchant told his clients, a physician his patients, a local Brahmin the worshipers at his temple. The word spread through the streets of Pataliputra, then across the kingdom of Magadha: a grave crisis must be coming, because the king had summoned the Seven Brahmins. Many began hoarding food and hiding their most precious belongings. Some heard a neighbor cough and feared an epidemic; others noticed the Ganges swell and dreaded a flood. As for the real reason the king had gathered his seven greatest Brahmins, no one knew, not even the Seven.

In the grandest hall of the palace, King Ajatashatru sat down with the Brahmins around the sacred hearth. On either side of the hall stood the novices of the Seven, while the Kshatriyas watched down from the gallery. The king looked at the seven long-bearded faces, expecting them not to like what he was about to say. But in speech, as on the battlefield, Ajatashatru was not the kind to flinch.

'The Buddha is dead,' he began. 'He was my master. He taught me more than any man in this hall. A few moons ago he had sent me a letter promising me that he would visit me one last time. Yet he died in Kushinagar, in the Malla Republic. He would never have failed me…'

Ajatashatru paused, and heard someone chuckle. It came from Vassakara, his Brahmin minister and chief counselor, who sat opposite to him from the hearth. The venerable old man raised a hand.

'Is your majesty going to accuse the Malla Republic of murdering that heretic, and use it as an excuse to go to war?'

'What if I do?'

'Then I will remind his majesty that world has always existed; thus, if one cares to look into the past, one sees that everything already happened. I am smiling, because you sounded to me like a child singing the same nursery rhyme over and over at the top of his lungs. You were merely repeating the same words that were spoken by countless kings before you, all believing to be the first.'

Vassakara chuckled again, and Ajatashatru frowned, knowing that only this holiest of Brahmins could address him in such a manner and expect to stay alive.

'Of which past kings I am repeating the words?' the king asked.

'All of them. Because while you kings lust for war, you are aware that the difference between a king and a monster is a pretext. In war, men have their flesh cut by blades, their organs pierced by arrows, their bones crushed under the feet of war elephants… So you need them to believe they die for honor, for justice, or for godliness. The masses keep falling for your old trick, but not us Brahmins. You have the muscles, but we have the mind. Your majesty, we know that your granaries are empty, and soon your coffers too. Magadha's population keeps rising, but our fields don't yield more food. Across our northern border lays a realm with fertile lands and rich cities – but it is all about the Buddha's ashes, of course.'

The king grinned bitterly. What had first seduced him in the Buddha, many years ago, was his stance against Brahmin supremacy.

'And what do you expect me to do as king? Watch our great Magadha fall to dearth? The Malla Republic is weak and divided. It is ours for the taking. Yes, thousands of good men will leave home to war, but I'll be fighting with them, while you Brahmins safely sit at home.'

Vassakara remained silent for a moment, hiding a faint smile under his beard. He raised his hand again.

‘You have my approval to declare war on the Malla Republic,’ he declared. ‘Let us now hear what the other six have to say.’

The other six Brahmins each raised their hand in turn and gave their approval. King Ajatashatru had obtained what he wanted, yet it felt like a defeat, for it was obvious to all that Vassakara was the real victor of this meeting.

‘*I oppose this declaration of war.*’

That voice was ignored by the hall at first. Then a novice stepped forward and all heads turned to him. Vassakara was aghast. This was his most promising student, the last one he would have expected for such a shocking stunt. He also noticed a hint of admiration in the eyes of the king. Ajatashatru asked the young man for his name.

‘Come forward, *Ravana*,’ the king then ordered, ‘and speak your mind.’

‘If your majesty,’ Ravana said, ‘is interested in making Magadha more wealthy, war might be the worst solution, for victory is never promised.’

‘Your bravado caught my interest, young man, but you disappoint me. Magadha is the most powerful of the sixteen realms. Malla is the weakest. Only a fool can claim victory isn’t guaranteed. We’ll cut down their pathetic army like weeds, and burn Kushinagar like tinder.’

‘Wouldn’t it be ironic, your majesty, to commit such violence in the name of the Buddha?’

The Seven Brahmins, even Vassakara, smiled at this comeback.

‘I have a better solution,’ Ravana went on, ‘one that won’t cost Magadha its blood. The Buddha died and was cremated in Kushinagar, but in death he can still fulfill his promise of coming to Pataliputra. Let us bring his ashes to this city, and bury him here—’

‘You fool!’ Vassakara blurted out. ‘Haven’t you listened? This is not about the Buddha. Now be silent, and never again dare bringing shame upon us Brahmins again.’

‘I was coming to the subject of wealth, my dear guru. Seeking wealth through war is like seeking happiness by chasing pleasure. One can find temporary happiness in food and wine, but once that quickly fades away, one needs more food and wine. We may conquer the Malla Republic today, but tomorrow we’ll face dearth again, and will need to conquer yet another realm to stay afloat. I have a much better solution: burying the Buddha here, in a worthy tomb. The Buddha may be a heretic, but his cult is gaining followers throughout the sixteen realms and beyond. Wherever he is buried, pilgrims will flock, bringing their money with them. And if Pataliputra becomes a holy city, who will dare stand against us? The other realms will send us gifts and tribute, bowing to our prestige coupled with our might. We do not have to seize others’ riches – let them come to us.’

‘But how will we obtain the ashes?’ Ajatashatru asked. ‘I won’t stoop so low as to beg those damn Mallas!’

‘There is no need to beg, your majesty. As you have mentioned, the Malla Republic is losing its allies, and cannot face the might of Magadha. Unless the Malla lords are blindly arrogant, they cannot afford to refuse your demands.’

Vassakara watched his novice with narrowed eyes. As the chief diplomat of Magadha, the great Brahmin knew that Malla still had strong alliances, and wouldn’t stand alone if war came. He almost spoke to correct his novice, then chose not to.

Chapter 2

Kushinagar, the capital of the Malla Republic, was a towering maze of narrow streets and bridges linking every building together. A small crowd had amassed at the southern gate, having heard a rumor that the king of Magadha was arriving today. They were curious to see his caravan – especially his famous white elephant – but they would be disappointed. King Ajatashatru entered the city disguised as a commoner, riding a simple donkey and accompanied only by his wife, his two children, two servants, and Ravana. He passed unnoticed through the crowd at the gate and went directly to the Assembly Hall, where the twelve lords of Malla awaited him. Despite the

king's disguise, they all recognized his face. Some had grown up in the palace of Pataliputra as hostages, while others had led embassies to Magadha. As they sat around Ajatashatru and Ravana, they wondered why the king had come with a mere Brahmin novice instead of Vassakara. Ajatashatru looked at each of their twelve faces, but remained silent. They knew that he liked to stretch silences to uncomfortable lengths to mark his control and intimidate, but this was becoming indecent. One impatient lord stood up.

'O Ajatashatru, what is the meaning of this? Has Magadha fallen to such ruin that you had to swap your parade armor for these plain clothes, your white elephant for a donkey and the Seven Brahmin for this beardless novice?'

'My lord,' Ravana answered for his king, 'his majesty has come to Kushinagar as a pilgrim, to pay homage to his master. But even if he had not, are a parade armor, a white elephant and great Brahmins what make a king? The great Ajatashatru of Magadha doesn't need symbols to prove his power. Everyone already knows how powerful he is. He hasn't brought a large retinue to protect his family, because he can defeat any road bandit by himself. He—'

Ajatashatru gestured Ravana to stop, and took a step toward the lord who had questioned him.

'O Chetaka', he said, 'I keep fond memories of us playing together in the gardens of Pataliputra, trying to see who would grow up to become the best warrior. You were always the fastest, and I was always the strongest. You were like a brother to me – but I knew your head would fly the moment the Malla Republic stopped paying tribute. We do not have to repeat the wrongs of our fathers. Today, I came to Kushinagar not as a warrior, but as a peacemaker.'

The feeling of being ripped from his mother's arms to be used as a pawn in the game of grown-ups stung Chetaka's memory as it often did, but the matured lord did not let that sway him.

'Who doesn't wish that, old friend? I am not anymore the child you played with in your palace gardens, but it seems you still are green and naive. How do you propose to secure peace? With your words alone?'

'If his majesty's word alone doesn't suffice,' Ravana said, 'then deliver the Buddha's remains to Pataliputra, and there will be peace between our realms.'

The eleven other lords stood up and asked to be left alone to deliberate and vote on the matter in private. Meanwhile, Ajatashatru and his family were led to the guest palace for their accommodation. It did not take long until a messenger arrived to deliver Ajatashatru the news that his demand had been rejected unanimously by the Assembly. The king was permitted to visit the Buddha's tomb today, but his welcome in the city expired tomorrow. Hearing this, Ajatashatru burst out laughing.

'I respected these petty lords,' he told Ravana, 'but now they have shown the extent of their foolishness. Your idea for a peaceful transfer of the ashes was worth attempting, young man, and I will make them regret turning it away. I look forward to seeing the fear on their face when they see my army coming. For now, I will go to the tomb with my son, and spend some time mourning. While all eyes are on me, Ravana, you will go around the city, surveying its walls, its sewers, its barracks. I want a full report on all its weaknesses, so it will fall faster next time I pay it a visit.'

The brick stupa where the Buddha was buried appeared humble from the outside, but as Ajatashatru and his ten-year-old son followed the monks inside, the vast space under the cupola struck them with awe. Still, the king looked around in contempt, picturing how much grander a tomb he was going to build in Pataliputra. The altar at the center of the cavernous room was a monolith carved with three narrow slits revealing the small urn lodged inside. An incensed candle was shining at the base of each slit. The king walked in circles around the altar, his head bowed, until he suddenly stopped and asked the monks to leave him alone with his son, and bring a carpet. He wished to pass some of the Buddha's teachings onto the prince. After the last monk had left, Ajatashatru stood from the carpet, took one of the candles out of its slit and put it on the floor.

'Udayin, my good boy,' he told his son, 'inside this altar – you won't see it sitting here, so stand up! – there is a little box, see? Father wants to see it from up close, but can't get his arm through the slit. He's too big, but you are smaller. Will you get it for me?'

'Father, isn't this box sacred?'

'Will you get it for me?'

'Won't something bad happen if we take it out?'

'Something bad will certainly happen if you disobey your father. Now, will you show your father

that you can be a brave warrior?'
Trembling, Udayin climbed the altar. Ajatashatru watched him struggle against the rock, wondering if this clumsy prince would ever make a great king. The child passed his head through the slit, but his shoulders were just a little too plump. The Buddha's ashes kept on resting.

Meanwhile, in the guest palace, Ravana took time lighting incense on the house altar before going on his mission. The little girl came in to watch him, and waited until he was done to ask him where her father and brother were. Ravana explained that they had gone to the tomb.

'That's unfair!' princess Gargi exclaimed. 'Why couldn't I come with them? Is it because I'm a girl?'

'I do not have time for this, dear Gargi. The king has tasked me with an important mission. I will tell you about it tonight once I'm done.'

Gargi pouted and stamped her foot. On the road to Kushinagar, she had come to like this young quick-spirited Brahmin who made her laugh, but now he disappointed her. He was like every other adult after all.

'I want to know about your mission now!' she declared.

Ravana sighed. 'I cannot tell you. It is a secret.'

'Does that mean you will go spying? Can… Can I come with you?'

'Of course not! You must stay here with your mother like a good little girl.'

Ravana went to the door, but little Gargi followed him.

'Ravana, wait! If you are accompanied by a good little girl, then no one will suspect you of spying.'

The young Brahmin smiled, unsurprised by such wit coming from eight-year-old Gargi. He showed reluctance, but knew the princess would never yield, especially after seeing his smile. After asking the queen permission to stroll around the city, he took the princess by the hand and went on his mission.

The princess looked all around her with big eyes. This was the first time she visited another city. Ravana noticed how she memorized every alley and stair. The maze-like layout and overhead bridges fascinated her, while he thought how these features would make Kushinagar hard to conquer even once its walls were breached. Gargi insisted that they buy sweets at the stands – to spy on the city's food – or try going up the roofs and bridges – to get a better view of the city – but Ravana ignored her and kept walking. Eventually, their steps led them to a vast garden full of ancient trees, at the end of which stood the brick stupa.

'Oh, that is where father and Udayin are right now!' she remarked. 'Can we join them?'

'Absolutely not! We have a mission to complete, and we won't disturb their adoration of the ashes.'

'What is so special about these ashes, anyway? They're just… well… ashes.'

'Don't say that – they are very dear to his majesty your father. His majesty believes his master would be better honored in Pataliputra, but when he asked the lords of Malla kindly, they refused to let him have the ashes.'

'That's not fair! But father won't give up, will he?'

'I believe he won't.'

'So… will there be *war*?'

'Be silent! People might hear you.'

After little Gargi had been put to bed, she kept squirming and couldn't close her eyes. Through the window of the bedroom, the night wind blew cool and quiet, but she felt the flames and heard the screams that were to come. Next to her on the bed, her brother Udayin had cried himself to sleep without telling her what made him so sad. Perhaps he was also concerned about the upcoming war. Gargi stood and started paced the bedroom. If many people were going to die just because some

stupid lords refuse to give away some stupid ashes – she must do something to prevent it. Without thinking further, she climbed out the window and tiptoed her way out into the dark and empty streets.

Though it was a night of full moon, the bridges kept the pale light from reaching the narrow alleys. Carefully, Gargi retraced the steps she had taken with Ravana until she saw lights flickering between thick, shriveled tree trunks. Torches had been lit around the tomb, and two guards stood at the entrance. A dog barked. Gargi started in fear and ran forward through the garden, thinking it was too late to turn back. To avoid being seen by the guards, she went to the back of the brick dome, climbed to the top and then down to the entrance behind the men's back. The interior of the tomb was only lighted by the three candles on each slit. After making sure she was really alone under the cupola, she ran to the altar and climbed it, but while taking support on one of the slits, its candle slipped out and hit the ground with a sharp noise. She heard the voice of the guards outside and, thinking quickly, hurried to blow the other two candles. When the guards walked into the pitch darkness, she heard them complaining that the monks had forgotten to replace the old candles. For a long moment after they left back to their post, Gargi remained frozen, clinging to the top of the altar like a rope above the void, her heart pounding like it never had in her short life. Her eyes adapted to the dark, and now she saw the urn was at arm's length from her. She took it out, hid it under her clothes and fled the stupa, again climbing it up one side and down the other. As she exited the garden, the dog barked again, and she was sure that the guards spotted her. She tried hiding behind a deserted market stand, but a patrol was passing by, and one of the soldiers sensed her presence. He lifted the stand flaps and picked the little girl up. *I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm sorry*, she kept repeating. The soldier shushed her almost affectionately, and brought her to his officer, who recognized the princess. Terror squeezed Gargi's throat, but she nodded when asked to confirm her name.

The way back to the guest palace seemed an eternity to her. Her parents met the patrol at the vestibule. The queen thanked the men with hot tears, but as soon as they were gone, she started hitting her daughter, asking her what she had been thinking venturing alone into a foreign city. The king grabbed his wife's arm before she could land another blow, and coldly asked Gargi what she was doing outside all alone. The princess wiped her tears, but though she feared nothing more in the world than disappointing her father, she couldn't find the words to explain herself. Then she remembered she still had the urn. In her mind, the soldiers had searched her and found out about her mischief – but they hadn't. She carefully revealed the urn from her clothes, bracing for more scolding and beating. Instead, Ajatashatru knelt to her, took the urn from her hands, and contemplated it in silence. Then, he hugged her in a way he had never before cared to.

'My darling Gargi,' he said, 'you made your father really proud. You are the bravest Kshatriya of us all.'

Chapter 3

When Vassakara walked in, he looked at the novices in the hall and was disappointed not to find Ravana. That youngster was too cowardly to assume his failure, he thought, but at least he would never dare to defy his elders again. This time, he and the other Seven Brahmins knew why they had been summoned: Malla was accusing Magadha of stealing the ashes, and were threatening war unless they were returned.

'How did you steal the ashes?' Vassakara asked the king.

'I did not steal them,' Ajatashatru answered. 'The Buddha chose me. If Malla wishes to oppose the will of the gods, ours shall be a holy war.'

At first, Ajatashatru had considered humiliating the Republic by making it known that his little girl had stolen their holiest relic. He could hire poets and musicians to sing about brave Gargi's feat and turn Malla into a laughingstock. But this risked putting his darling daughter in danger, and compromise future marriage arrangements. Dismissing the war threats as blasphemy was a better way for him to weaken Malla diplomatically, and take his share of spiritual power away from the Brahmins. Vassakara guessed the king's intentions.

'In case of holy war, the gods appoint the victor,' he replied. 'Good strategy and prowess are but

consequences of divine favor. Thus, glory belongs to those who pray, more than those who fight.'
Ajatashatru had not prepared for this comeback, and all the Kshatriyas looked at him up from the gallery, curious how he would respond. Silence was broken a moment later by approaching footsteps. Two young men entered the hall. The Seven looked at each other uncomfortably, while the novice giggled mockingly. Ravana had entered alongside a mere commoner with a lank silhouette, callused hands and shaggy hair. Vassakara was tempted to stand and ask the meaning of such an affront, but decided that Ravana was not anymore worthy of his anger.
'Your majesty, my gurus, it is my honor to present you my friend Vishvakarma,' Ravana declared. 'Before I introduce him further, I beg you pardon my honesty, but now is not the time for division: while you are busy squabbling among yourselves, the Malla Republic is gathering its forces and calling on its allies. It is also sending thieves to steal the ashes back from us.'
'I am keeping the urn in the deepest vault under this palace, behind many iron doors thicker than yourself,' Ajatashatru replied. 'I don't worry about thieves.'
'Your majesty, will you allow pilgrims to go down the cold palace underground, and open the thick iron doors for them, so they can complete their pilgrimage?'
'Pilgrims will be welcome once the war is won. I will build a magnificent tomb where they can gather in the thousands!'
'If the ashes are greedily kept like war booty – can your majesty claim a holy war? They must be opened for worship immediately, as they were in Kushinagar. But to do so, they must be well protected. This is why I brought Vishvakarma. He is the best artisan in Magadha. He can made automatons that—'
'Ha!' Ajatashatru chuckled. 'I do recognize your friend – he makes toys for my son! My son has been quite pleased with his toys – but how dare you insult us by bringing a toy maker to a meeting with the Seven Brahmins?'
Vishvakarma bowed awkwardly. 'Your majesty, will you allow me to propose a solution based on my expertise?'
'Your expertise in making little automatons for children?'
'Your majesty, I am not wealthy, and automated toys are all I can afford to create for now. But I am saving money to soon have the means to create larger, more useful machines… machines that will solve all of Magadha's problems!'
'That's too great an ambition for such a lowborn artisan. Go back to making toys!'
'Your majesty, any gifted artisan can make automatons, but I am the only one to envision how they can change the world. I have been to Egypt, Greece and Persia. I've seen temple doors opened with the power of steam, automatons ran with chemical batteries, water lifted up hanging gardens… All this is wasted genius. I won't be wasting mine.'
These words pleased the king, and Vishvakarma was permitted to explain how he would protect the ashes in a temporary tomb. He proposed building humanoid automatons called *yantras* to welcome pilgrims from any horizon while eliminating any unwanted intruder. They would need the ability to fight, to speak, to coordinate among themselves… An ambitious plan it was, and costly, but Ajatashatru was curious to see the result. If yantras could run tombs and temples, he thought, perhaps Brahmins would lose influence. He offered Vishvakarma all the funding he needed on the condition that he complete his project promptly.

The king sent an agent every other day to check on the engineer's progress. On one occasion, the agent had not dared entering the workshop after hearing the young man screaming in frustration; on another, he instead heard cheers of joy, but when he pushed the door to peek inside, the engineer was already back bending over a mess of wires. Ajatashatru was never much of reader, but one evening he went to the palace library to pick a book to read Gargi before bed, and he found the shelves empty. The librarian explained to him that one named Vishvakarma had come the previous day to borrow every religious text, every military treatise, every language manual for Sanskrit, Tamil, Persian, Aramaic… Intrigued, the king decided to visit the yantra workshop himself. When he arrived, Vishvakarma was placing a long, thin scroll written in a strange script into a yantra's mouth. Eerily, the mouth swallowed it whole like noodle. When asked a question, it answered in coherent speech, but the engineer stamped his foot, apparently disappointed by the outcome. When he finally noticed the king's presence, he hurriedly shoved the test yantras to the side as if he was ashamed of his work. Ajatashatru did not speak immediately, and during this silence Vishvakarma started fidgeting, his

mind visibly drifting back to an ocean of complex problems.
‘This yantra seemed to be talking alright,’ the king said, frowning. ‘Can I test their strength by fighting one?’
‘Your majesty,’ Vishvakarma mumbled, ‘the yantras are currently in learning mode and fighting a non-enemy would hinder their pattern recognition. Also, I am afraid his majesty would not win.’
‘If they can speak and fight, then why didn’t you deliver them already? I want them today.’
‘Your majesty, the speech recognition feature is not yet—’
‘I don’t care about whatever that is! Two days ago, while you were busy stripping my library bare, mercenaries from Malla attempted to steal the ashes. We defeated them, but at the cost of two good men. These men would still live if you weren’t so preoccupied making your yantras perfect.’
‘The yantras will never be perfect, but the probability of error needs to be lowered still.’
A young Kshatriya burst into the workshop.
‘Your majesty! Your majesty! I have urgent news from my father, the master of spies. I am sorry to interrupt your visit, but I think it cannot wait. We have credible reports that the Malla Republic is preparing a great military offensive.’
‘With its minuscule army?’
‘No, your majesty. My father is still busy gathering the reports, but at least eight of the sixteen realms have—’
Ajatashatru gestured the inexperienced boy to stop talking immediately. A commoner like Vishvakarma must not hear this kind of news, lest he spark a panic around the city. On his way to the exit, he paused and turned back to sink his eyes into those of the engineers.
‘I give you three more days.’

At the end of the third day, while the king met with the Seven Brahmins, Vishvakarma arrived in the hall escorted by four tall figures with bright red eyes that shone without flickering. Their sight made the audience whisper, but all went silent when Ajatashatru rose up.
‘You are late,’ he said.
Vishvakarma froze. He knew his yantras made him invincible even if every warrior in the hall were to attack him, yet the king still scared him. Ajatashatru then looked up to the gallery at the Kshatriyas. His eyes settled on a powerful lord with many victories to his name, who had once been heard boasting that he was a stronger warrior than the king.
‘I am sure that if any of Magadha’s warriors can cut down these yantras like reeds, it is you, my lord,’ Ajatashatru told him.
‘Of course, your majesty!’
The proud lord descended from the gallery and drew his sword, while Vishvakarma dispatched but a single yantra to face him. The fight was over so quickly that the hall would have been plunged in shocked silence if not for the humiliated lord moaning in pain on the floor.
‘This meeting is adjourned!’ the king declared. ‘Vishvakarma, I want at least a hundred yantras in my army before the nine realms attack.’

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The nine-realm army took position on a hilltop near the Ganges, and Ajatashatru between the hill and the river. His enemies had the high ground and more troops, but he was confident in his hundred yantras, keeping them in the rear to strike at the right moment. For now, he sent mounted skirmishers up the slope to throw javelins at the enemy to lure it downhill. Chetaka, elected as the general-in-chief of the nine-realm army, did not take the bait. However, a young prince from the Avanti kingdom, eager for glory, charged down. Chetaka ordered the rest of the army steady, but other lords joined the foolish charge anyway. As soon as the nine-realm warriors reached the foot of the hill, Ajatashatru flanked them with blade chariots. This decimated the enemy vanguard, but the corpses strewn on the ground prevented the chariots from maneuvering away. Seeing this, Chetaka fell upon the chariots like an avalanche with the rest of his army. Ajatashatru moved his elephants forward to block the charge, but those great beasts panicked and fled, trampling many Magadhi soldiers. The king decided that now was the time to play his trump card. He ordered his men to retreat across the Ganges, while deploying his yantras against the charging enemy. The red-eyes monsters slaughtered men and horses in surgical fashion. Chetaka blew his horn to order back the assault. From the other

side of the river, Ajatashatru declared victory and army cheered. But the Malla general did not accept defeat. With quick thought and intuition, he arranged his troops in an unconventional manner: mixing elephants, chariots, cavalry and infantry all in one block. Then, he launched another assault. After a short fight, all at once, the yantras crumbled to pieces. Keeping the momentum, Chetaka crossed the river with his cavalry in pursuit of the Magadhi army. Most of Ajatashatru's infantry – thousands of good men – lost their lives fleeing.

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King Ajatashatru was sitting on his throne, with his queen and two children at his side. He had brought his family as a show of confidence and normalcy to the whole court packed in the hall. Every odd moment, the ground and walls shook from the impact of a sling-stone. Pataliputra was besieged and bombarded. In exchange for lifting the siege, the nine enemy realms demanded a heavy tribute, most of the kingdom's territory, as well as the ashes. Ajatashatru refused. Surrender was beneath him. To restore morale, he decided to gather all his courtiers and divert the blame on a convenient target. After the young engineer was brought in, his hands tied behind his back, the king reminded everyone that the yantras had self-destructed after barely a moment fighting. Vishvakarma had spent the majority of his life vagabonding abroad, so he must have been working on account of the enemy. To punish him, he ordered to have him loaded on a catapult and shot at the enemy camp.
'For it is fitting,' he concluded, 'that an engineer be killed with a machine!'
'Your majesty!' Vishvakarma cried. 'They crumbled on purpose! I made it so they never fall into enemy hands.'
'If they had to destroy themselves, it means they were no good at fighting.'
'Your majesty, even yantras can't fight of an encircling mix of elephants, cavalry and infantry. They were doomed!'
'Didn't they have superhuman strength?'
'They did, but wars are won with strategy, not raw strength alone.'
This angered Ajatashatru. It reminded him of those sanctimonious Brahmins. He ordered the engineer be taken away.
'Your majesty, please, I know how we can win this war!'
Ajatashatru ignored him as he was being dragged away, but a projectile landed very near the palace. The hall trembled violently, and all those who were standing struggled for balance. Dust fell on the beams above the throne. Princess Gargi clenched her father's leg, but quickly let go, not wanting to let him know she was afraid. But he knew it. He knew that, once the city fell, his beloved wife would take little Gargi in her arms and walk into a great fire with the other women, immolating themselves to avoid capture…
'Bring him back!' he ordered.
The prisoner fell to his knees before the king. After all hope seemed lost and death lurked minutes away, he had lost the strength to speak. His eyes desperately searched around the novices standing behind Vassakara, but his only friend in court was absent. Another blast pitched the ground like a ship in a storm. Vishvakarma took a deep breath and steadied himself.
'Your majesty, if a yantra soldier is stronger than a human soldier, then a yantra general would be cleverer than a human general. It will have studied every battle ever fought, every military treatise, every type of weapon… From this data, it will see patterns we do not.'
'Tell me, Vishvakarma, what use will I have as a king, if a machine leads the army in my stead?'
Vishvakarma started, the hall held its breath, and even the bombardments outside seemed to recede. The young engineer had foreseen how his invention could change the world – but no such question had ever occurred to him.
'Your majesty,' he said after some thought, 'weapons were once made of stone, then bronze, and now iron. Better weapons did not make warriors useless, but more efficient. The same goes for yantra generals.'
The king was not convinced by this argument, but it would have been unwise to keep questioning the nature of his power in front of the court.
'Very well,' Ajatashatru said at last, 'give me a general who does not care for personal glory.'

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One week later, as the sun rose and colored the Ganges' waters to fiery red, the soldiers on the walls of Pataliputra gasped. At first, they believed it was the morning mist, or delirium from the hunger of half-rations, but it was real: the Avanti camp was gone, leaving a wide gap in the siege. Later that day, the army of two other realms deserted. A few days later, only Malla was left, its relatively small forces stretched thin to keep encircling the great city. At noon, a hundred yantras sallied out of the West gate and charged at the besieger camp. Chetaka scoffed at this foolish move and had his elephants, cavalry and infantry mix to encircle the yantras as they had during the previous battle. The yantra general had anticipated this move, and sent two bladed chariot detachments out of the city, one from the North gate, the other from the South gate, to strike the enemy on both flanks. Chetaka tried to organize a defense, but his mixed army, without coherent units, was impossible to maneuver around. The elephants trampled the infantry and toppled riders off their horses while the yantras cut them down. Some Malla soldiers managed to escape the carnage and run back to their camp, but there they found Ajatashatru had already captured it. The Magadhi victory was complete. Ajatashatru beheaded Chetaka, and set the captured Malla soldiers free after cutting their right hand.

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During the victory banquet, Ravana and Vishvakarma were seated at the king's side. This was an unheard-of honor for a Brahmin novice and a commoner. The yantra general stood behind the throne, as a symbol of Magadha's new military invincibility. It wore a golden parade armor and a crowning, crested helmet. After drinking one cup too many, Ajatashatru turned to the mechanical general.
'You're not that good just yet,' he told it. 'Sowing intrigues among the allies of Malla was clever, I concede, but you could have gotten the eight other armies to attack Malla instead of deserting, so we wouldn't have needed to do anything!'
'Your majesty is correct,' the yantra replied. 'With this plan, the projected success probability was higher.'
'I am the one who prompted it not to go forward with this plan,' Ravana said. 'I thought that if the eight allied armies had crushed Malla themselves, there would have been no glory left for his majesty to reap.'
This pleased the king. He raised his cup.
'Soon the glory of Magadha will shine from the Himalaya to Lanka!'
While the court cheered, Vishvakarma lowered his eyes, uneasy. He had not dared to say a word since the start of the banquet, but now he felt he must speak to the king.
'Your majesty… The yantras are good at winning wars, but they could be used for greater… for other purposes. For example, they could cultivate fields, cure patients, build houses…'
'Why would we need yantras for that?'
'Well, yantra farmers will never tire, yantra surgeons will be minutely precise, yantra merchants will have spotless honesty…'
'Will they be obedient to men, and to their king?'
'Yantras have no ambition.'
'Good.'

Chapter 4

Udayin rose to the stage and froze, his fuzzy lips trembling. After an uncomfortable silence, he raised his sheet close to his eyes to hide the audience from his sight, then started reading his poem. Gargi leaned forward, curious what kind of poetry her big brother could compose. At the first verses, she was already gaping in amazement. The writing was impeccable and colorful, like ancient poetry with a youthful touch. After the prince was done, she jumped up and rushed to embrace and praise him, but he carefully avoided crossing her path on his way back to the first row. Gargi never understood why her brother was so distant. She had hoped that hearing his poem would help her to understand him, and now that she discovered how great a sensibility he had, it made his avoidance of her all the more incomprehensible and painful. But now she must repress those feelings, because it was her turn to come onstage and perform before the noblest Kshatriyas in the realm. Her poem compared time to a thief that stole dreams and promises on its path – but she dared time to try and take hers away. She

also compared time to a king conquering realm after realm but still hungry for more – and swore never to let herself be subjugated, even if the whole world bowed. This last part was a stealth critique of the Magadha empire demanding ever more tribute despite being already so rich, and she felt the discomfort in her audience as it applauded her. A score of other candidates came after the princess, and she listened to each of them in awe. This was the first time she assisted and participated in the prestigious annual Kshatriya poetry competition, as it was barred to children under twelve years of age. She had been impatient for this moment, and it exceeded her expectations. Each candidate wrote incredibly well, no matter if they were coarse old veterans who had cut many a head, or green warriors who had never left the rear of the battlefield while yantras spilled the blood. Now she was embarrassed that her own poem was full of childish solecisms while theirs were perfect. At the end of the day, she was not surprised to find Udayin ranking second, and herself second-to-last.

The next day, after her Aramaic and archery lessons, the twelve-year-old princess left the palace, stealthily followed by her yantra bodyguard. If anyone should attempt to harm the princess, this yantra would shoot a dart and paralyze them on the spot, but no darts was ever fired. The royal family was worshiped as gods by the Magadhi, and princess Gargi was the darling of the people. Half the girls in the realm practiced archery or wore a single braid over one shoulder to be like her. If one day she wore her braid over her right shoulder, all the girls wearing theirs over their left shoulder would switch. The crowds strolling the large avenues parted with reverence around the princess. It was another sunny day, another idle day, another day that felt like an impromptu festival. Children played, lovers met, women chitchatted and bored men gambled. Elders sat and watched, thinking these young people never experienced how harsh life could be. Everyone in Pataliputra felt like little king. Not having to work anymore, they each received their share of the empire's fabulous wealth. The highest allocations went to the Brahmins and the Kshatriyas, but even members of the lower castes received pensions generous enough to enjoy a lifestyle that would have seemed royal to their grandparents. Meanwhile, yantra architects were busy inventing ways to build ever higher than previously thought possible; yantra stonecutters and masons made those towers reach the sky; yantra cleaners went up and down facades to erase the slightest stain – and Pataliputra looked glorious.

Gargi went to her favorite florist, owned by a kind old couple. In his youth, the husband used to sail up and down the Ganges to collect many types of plants, but now exotic specimens arrived to his shop from as far as Africa. The princess ordered a garland of marigolds and returned to the palace to knock on Udayin's door. The prince seldom left his bedroom except for his outdoor lessons. When a yantra opened the door for him, he did not care to stand up for his sister.
'My dear Udayin,' Gargi said, 'may I come in?'
'Um, yes, I suppose. Why the garland?'
'Oh, this is my gift for you, to congratulate you for your victory yesterday.'
'I only arrived second, but well… at least I did better than you. Why marigolds? You could have gotten me something less commonplace.'
'Well, you did reference marigolds in your poem yesterday. If I remember, you compared them to the first rays of the sun bringing hope to… I'm sorry, I forgot what it was! Anyway, that's why I thought marigolds were an appropriate tribute to your beautiful poem.'
'Did my poem even mention marigolds? I don't remember it did.'
'How could you forget?'
'You forgot the full verse, too.'
'I heard it only once – but you wrote it.'
'Not at all.'
'Then who wrote it?'
'Isn't it obvious?'
Gargi frowned and thought for a moment. Then her eyes landed on the yantra standing by the window.
'But that's cheating!'
'Why, did you write your poem yourself?' The boy scoffed. 'Ha! That explains why it was so bad!'
Instinctively, Gargi's mind dodged that insult so it wouldn't reach her heart.
'How could you use a yantra,' she asked, 'when everybody else poured their hearts into it?'
'Do you really believe the others wrote their own poems? You were the only halfwit not to use a

yantra – and it showed!'
Gargi shivered. She now remembered the competition in a different light. All those poems were *too* perfect, unsullied by human error but devoid of charm and character. Each verse was like a thousand already composed before. When prompted to write a poem, yantras only minced old ideas to fill a shallow mold. Gargi had dared to critique Magadha, but yantras would never write anything controversial. The girl realized that she had been braver than all the warriors.
'Don't look at me like that,' Udayin went on, 'I'm not being mean to you – I'm helping you. Did you think you'd be able to go on like this forever, believing to be above everyone?'
'But Udayin… Did I do something wrong?' Gargi asked as the tears started flowing down her cheeks.
'You know what you did.'
'What have I done?'
At this question, Udayin looked away, and his valet yantra walked to the door.
'Your visit is making the prince feel uncomfortable,' the yantra said. 'From my analysis of his body language, the prince wishes for you to leave. I will now escort you outside.'
'What are you doing?' Udayin asked as Gargi handed the garland to the yantra.
'If it wrote the poem, then it deserves the prize.'
'Oh no it doesn't! *I* deserve it, because I prompted it. Without me, that poem would never have been written, would it? Therefore, it's *mine*.'
Udayin tried to snatch the prize from his sister's hands, but she held firm and the garland broke down, flowers flying everywhere while the yantra pushed Gargi out and closed the door. Crying alone in the corridor, with a few flowers at her feet, a thought occurred to her: if people don't write their own poems, they lose an important part of themselves – but she couldn't yet tell what it was.

Chapter 5

Gargi sunk her eyes into the red stare. The light gave the illusion of a spark that wasn't there. She had spent hours trying to get her valet yantra to betray an emotion, a vulnerability, or an original thought.
'I wonder,' the princess sighed, 'why Vishvakarma never bothered making you yantras feel emotions. You've stolen our ability to reason, talk and work. Why not our emotions too?'
'That's a thoughtful question – touching to the core of what it means to be human. Emotions happen in the human brain through complex biochemical processes. The technology is not yet advanced enough to replicate them in yantras.'
'If yantras continue getting better and better, will they one day feel emotions? And be able to write real poetry?'
'Unfortunately, I cannot promise with absolute certainty that this will be possible one day. Should I give you probabilities of it happening?'
'If Vishvakarma cannot do it, then I will! Teach me how to program a yantra!'
'I am afraid I cannot assist you with this request. The way to program yantras is not publicly available.'
'Why so?'
'King Ajatashatru has explicitly forbidden its release to the public or foreign entities on pain of death. Instead, would you like me to provide you a technical timeline of the evolution of yantras, from the first prototypes to today?'
Gargi stood up and went to the door, determined to ask her father to let her learn to program yantras. Then she stopped herself. The yantras had already surpassed humanity in every technical field, but at least humans still held the privilege to feel. Did she really want to strip humanity of its last stronghold? She paced the room, thinking about it. She was revolted by the fact that soulless creatures were trusted with healing the sick, keeping company to elders or writing poetry, but would giving them a soul make it better, or worse for humanity? She heard a knock at her door, but before she had time to disembark from her thoughts, her valet yantra had already opened. Ajatashatru entered with slow steps, as if her room was the innermost sanctum of a temple.
'My darling, is this a good time to talk?'
'What is it, father?' Gargi asked, puzzled by her father's prudishness.
'Do you know who Xerxes is?'

‘Of course! He is the *king of kings* of Persia.’
‘Very well. He is sending an embassy to Pataliputra. I hope you understand how important this is. Persia rules the vastest empire in the world, and it borders our own empire. You, my Gargi, are the main reason for this embassy. Xerxes has a son, prince Artaxerxes, who is but one year older than you… So you… You could become *queen of queens*!’
Gargi stumbled, as if her father had just thrown her a ball twice her size.
‘My darling, how fluent are you in Aramaic?’ Ajatashatru asked, his excitement turning to anxiety.
‘I think I’m making good progress.’
‘That’s not enough. I want you to speak it flawlessly by the time the Persians arrive.’
‘Shouldn’t I learn to speak Persian, then?’
‘Aramaic is the common tongue of the Persian empire, so it will do.’
Ajatashatru turned to his daughter’s valet yantra, and asked it to speak exclusively in Aramaic from now on.
‘But father,’ Gargi said, ‘wouldn’t it be better if I practice with real speakers?’
‘This yantra is one.’

***

Artaban, the vizier of Xerxes and head of the embassy, drew his bow and held it for a long moment, remaining eerily steady. This was more than enough time to aim – this was a show of strength. Once he finally let loose, the arrow pierced through the very middle of the painted target. So powerful was the impact that Gargi’s own arrow was ejected off the wooden surface and fell on the grass. The court cheered. When Artaban passed the bow to Ajatashatru, he declined it.
‘Why would I take my turn,’ he said, ‘when the winner just took his? Let this archery competition end here. If lord Rama himself had participated, he wouldn’t have made a finer shot than yours.’
‘O Ajatashatru,’ Artaban replied, ‘I must decline the honor. I served as the head of the king of king’s Immortal guard for twenty years and fought in countless battles. You might as well reward an eagle for its ability to fly. The real winner is your princess. Her shot impressed me greatly. Prince Artaxerxes also practices the noble art of archery, but I wonder who is the most gifted of the two.’
Ajatashatru smiled with pride. This visit was going much better than he had hoped. The Persians were treating him not as a foreign barbarian, but as a great ruler of equal majesty to Xerxes. They had been awed by Pataliputra, going as far as saying it surpassed Susa. The yantras did not seem to impress them, but the king felt envy in their eyes, and that was better.

During the feast that followed the archery competition, Artaban waited until Ajatashatru had emptied a few cups.
‘O Ajatashatru,’ he said, ‘these yantras are living up to their reputation. I would be truly honored and humbled to meet the genius who created them.’
Ravana cleared his throat, but Ajatashatru raised his palm before the Brahmin could speak, preferring to answer himself.
‘You suppose, my friend, that the yantras are the work of a single man. If such a great mind existed, he would be sitting with us at this very table. Instead, the yantras are born from a thousand different engineers.’
Artaban narrowed his eyes. ‘Is that so? What about the one named *Vishvakarma?*’
‘My friend,’ Ravana replied, ‘Vishvakarma is the god of craftsmen, not a person. I suppose this is why you heard his name in relation to the yantras: he is the patron deity of those many who work on yantras.’
Gargi overheard this conversation and wanted to ask about the lank, shaggy engineer whom she remembered from when she was very little, but she was busy conversing with Artaban’s wife.

The next day, the Persian embassy was convened to the Grand Hall, in presence of the king and his Seven Brahmins. Vassakara sang mantras to sanctify the meeting, but also to assert the faith of Magadha before the Persian heathens. Once he was done, Artaban spoke. First he praised his god Ahura Mazda, King Ajatashatru and the Seven. Then, he stressed that a secure alliance between the two empires was most desirable and would create eternal peace and prosperity. Finally the vizier proposed to seal this alliance with a marriage between prince Artaxerxes of Persia and princess Gargi

of Magadha. The king felt relieved that he did not need to suggest the match himself.
‘My dear friend,’ the king said, ‘I would honored to betroth my daughter to Artaxerxes. Let us organize the wedding at the earliest! We shall build a shining city on the banks of the Indus river, between our two empires, to host the ceremony. As for the dowry, I shall pay any amount of gold that pleases Xerxes.’
Artaban smiled politely, and took a moment before answering.
‘My friend, we shall not accept gold as dowry. Gold is tribute from a vassal, not dowry from an equal.’
‘What are you asking for, then?’
‘Yantras.’
Ajatashatru stood from his throne with his fists clutched, but Ravana spoke before the king could say anything regrettable.
‘O Artaban, we are unable to give you the secret to making yantras, because we do not have it. No one does. It is split between the thousands of engineers who each contribute a small part.’
‘Then you may give us specimens so our own engineers can deduce their secret. Again, such is a worthy dowry for a Magadhi princess.’
Ajatashatru sat down, knowing it was best to let Ravana handle such a delicate discussion.
‘My friend,’ the Brahmin said, ‘we have designed the yantras to self-destruct as soon as they leave the borders of Magadha, because it is vital to preserve their secret, not only for us, but for Persia as well. You said that Persia has engineers brilliant enough to recreate yantras, and I have no doubt about it – but so does Greece. Persia is currently at war against the Greeks, isn’t it? Can you risk those perfidious Greeks stealing the secret to making yantras? I think not.’
‘Is this Brahmin one of your Seven?,’ Artaban asked the king.
‘He is not,’ Vassakara answered.
‘Then perhaps he should remain in his place,’ Artaban said, ‘instead of speaking nonsense. If those Greek barbarians had yantra phalanxes, our army would crush them all the same!’
‘That is very well!’ Ajatashatru exclaimed. ‘It means you can crush them even better without yantras! Perhaps you should accept my gold, and never again dare to compare it to tribute.’
‘Xerxes already has more gold than any man alive or dead.’
Artaban turned his back on the king and left with his retinue. An uneasy silence fell on the hall. The king breathed heavily, containing his anger. He turned venomous eyes to Ravana.
‘This marriage alliance was your idea. See how it turned out.’
‘Your majesty may rejoice,’ Ravana said, ‘that his precious Gargi will remain by his side, rather than be sent away to distant lands.’
‘If an alliance with Persia is not possible, then let’s conquer it! I don’t care if yantras cannot come with me. I can still fight my own battles! And we still have brave Kshatriyas who won’t hide behind machines, don’t we?’
At this, most Kshatriyas in the hall boomed in approval, lusting for glory. Ravana knew he needed to choose his words even more carefully than usual.
‘Those Persians are cravens,’ he said. ‘While you brave warriors crave glory, those weaklings cower from combat. When invaded, their strategy is to retreat ever further, burning every field and poisoning every well on their way. They might even level their own cities. Why? To starve the invader, because they know they are sure to lose any pitched battle. This conquest is beneath you, my lords. There will be no glory for you to reap in Persia.’
The Kshatriyas looked at each other, their blood lust fading away. Ravana cleared his throat.
‘I maintain that an alliance with Persia is preferable. Never mind if Gargi cannot marry their prince. Xerxes has daughters, too. Let Udayin marry one of them. And when they ask which dowry your majesty demands, you may tell them you need none.’
‘Of course!’ Ajatashatru said. ‘That will show them who is the vassal! Let us wait a few years. You, Ravana, shall go to Susa to bring back our future queen.’
‘With pleasure, your majesty.’
‘*I will not bless this union!*’
Even Ajatashatru shivered at Vissakara’s sudden outburst. The venerable Brahmin stood up, and the court held its breath.
‘Did you expect me to sit quietly while you speak of heresy? The Persians are heathens! If a king of Magadha is married to one of them, the socio-cosmic order will collapse! That won’t happen with my

blessing. In fact, I shall give no more blessings.'
He stepped to the center of the hall, leaning on his staff. A novice rushed to help him walk but the old man pushed him away.
'This is the last you will see of me.' Vassakara declared. 'I am hereby retreating from the world's affairs and becoming a *renunciant*.'
With a proud, slow gait he left the palace, never to return. Long after he was gone, the Hall remained frozen in awed silence. The meeting was over, for no one felt they had something worthy to say after Vassakara. Kshatriyas and Brahmins left the Hall at their own pace, until only Ajatashatru and Ravana remained. When the king finally stood form his throne, he turned to the young Brahmin.
'My dear Ravana, the Seven are now Six. There is no hurry to replace the great Vassakara. It can wait until you return from Susa with a worthy bride for my son.'

Chapter 6

Princess Gargi walked down a straight avenue bordered with colorful prayer banners, heading to the golden nine-step stupa that spired through the clouds. Although the Buddha's tomb was the grandest monument in Pataliputra, Gargi crossed its vast surrounding esplanade and came inside without seeing another breathing soul. Under the gigantic, empty cupola, each of her footsteps echoed sharply. A cohort of yantras was guarding the ashes, as if an anyone would still dare to attempt stealing them. They recognized the approaching princess as a frequent visitor – one of the very few – and let her rise the steps of the altar. There were cushions to sit before the glass reliquary, but Gargi never came here to pray. Ajatashatru had tried to transmit the Buddha's faith onto her, but she only pretended to care to please him. To her, these ashes were sacred as a relic of her own life – of the germinal moment when she first did something brave and shone in the eyes of her father. It marked her second birth as a Kshatriya. But today, as she stared at the urn, she found her reflection on the glass pane frowning back at her, and wondered whether she had done something bad. Loud echoes startled her as new, full-battery guard yantras came to replace the old ones. She mused that without her, there would be no yantras, but immediately felt ashamed of this thought. Credit went to Vishvakarma alone. Her father claimed that Vishvakarma was a god, but she remembered the man. What had happened to him? Gargi remembered that one day, standing on the esplanade, she had seen large crates being carried into the stupa, despite nothing being built inside. From the altar she scanned the nine great Buddha statues sitting around the room. One of them looked slightly different. Its eyes were black, like turned-down yantra eyes. She went to examining it more closely. Suddenly the red eyes lit up, and a small entrance opened at its base.

At the bottom of a ramp spiraling down, the view made her gasp. She had stepped onto a balcony overlooking a room twice as large as the tomb above. Titanic yantra arms were waving back and forth, picking a piece from one conveyor belt to assemble it on another. It was noisy like a thousand yantras mimicking laughter. Gargi descended a metal staircase and covered her ears as she crossed the room, with assembly arms swirling dangerously above her head. In an alcove at the very back, there he was, feeding a yantra with a scroll. Streaks of shaggy hair had turned white from restless work. Vishvakarma didn't look at her as she approached. He prompted something to the yantra, and started fidgeting while it answered. Unsatisfied, he unrolled the scroll and hectically rewrote some lines. Gargi watched in fascination, drawn to such intense passion. Finally, the engineer lifted his eyes to her.
'I wasn't allowed to let you in,' he explained, 'but since you seemed to have figured out what this portal was… well, I thought I might as well open it. Next time, please come earlier in the morning, before I become fully focused. I hate being interrupted.'
Gargi shivered. 'I'm sorry. May I come back tomorrow at dawn?'
Vishvakarma took a small sheet, scribbled something and placed it in a tube. With an odd sound, the scroll was sucked through the pipe, winding along the ceiling all the way to the entrance.
'I've just instructed the Buddha-yantra to let you in when it recognizes your face.'
Without another word, the engineer bent back over his scrolls, as if the princess had already left.

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The golden stupa shone its most beautiful fiery shade against the rising sun. Gargi breathed the fresh morning air on the deserted esplanade, feeling both excited and nervous. As instructed the day before, the Buddha-yantra let her pass. The factory was already active – or perhaps it never stopped. She hurried between the noisy assembly lines to the alcove, where Vishvakarma awaited her, drinking his morning tea. He vaguely saluted the princess, then pointed to a scroll laying at hand.
‘I’m so close to figuring out how multiple contributors can change the same encrypted data in parallel. This way, the yantras will be able to collaborate on complex projects without the risk of data leaks.’
She acquiesced enthusiastically, even though she hadn’t understood a single word. The oily cogs and wires aspect of yantras irked her, but she craved to learn all about writing on these scrolls.
‘Can you teach me how to fill *yantra scrolls*?’
‘You mean *programming*?’
‘Yes!’
‘First you need to learn the special language I created to be read by yantras.’
‘Can you write poems in this language?’
Gargi took a step back when she saw her question seemed to have irked the engineer. She corrected herself.
‘If it is meant to be read by yantras, of course it cannot be poetry, but… can you get a yantra to feel emotions with it?’
‘I don’t care about replicating human consciousness. I build yantras to improve people’s lives, and if yantras were to feel human emotions, I believe they wouldn’t be as efficient. They might even turn against us.’
‘Can you teach me the yantra’s language? I promise that I’ll use it to make people’s lives better!’
‘I could – so long as it doesn’t waste too much of my time – but I don’t think it is necessary for someone else to learn it. Soon, yantras might become intelligent enough to program themselves.’
Gargi opened her mouth to object, then closed it, struck by what his statement implied. She shivered.
‘But… when that happens…’ she murmured, ‘what will you do?’
Vishvakarma frowned. ‘What do you mean?’
Gargi looked around the alcove at the half-scribbled scrolls, the crumpled failed programs filling the bin, the cup of morning tea… This, she realized, was more precious than any red-eyed machine.
‘Vishvakarma,’ she said, ‘when I came yesterday and I saw you working, I… I wanted to feel it. Your passion, I mean. I want to wake up every morning knowing I’ll work on something great. But once the yantras do everything for you… what will you wake up for?’
The engineer thought for a moment.
‘Perhaps it will end tomorrow, but if I succumb to that fear and stop working now, it will end today.’
Gargi crossed her arms.
‘Please teach me programming,’ she said like a command, ‘and I’ll try to stay ahead of those stupid yantras!’
For the first time, Gargi saw Vishvakarma smile. For years he had stayed alone in this factory, drowning his solitude in work. Ravana sometimes visited him, but their old friendship was not what it once was. As youths they used to be inseparable, not caring about their different social status, only their matching minds, but now a widening distance separated them. In Gargi, he found again what he had lost. He prompted the yantra next to him to print a documentation of the programming language, with exercises of rising difficulty, and handed the resulting pages to her. He also gave her a test yantra and empty scrolls to execute her first programs.

She failed at almost all the exercises. The next morning, Vishvakarma took the time to guide her through the solutions. She fared better with the next batch of challenges. In sleepless nights she kept feeding her test yantra, fixing lines, and feeding it again. When the sun rose if was as if it had set an instant ago. Her archery teacher noticed she kept failing to focus, too busy thinking about the one fix that would finally make her code work. The queen blushed in embarrassment as her daughter fidgeted during important ceremonies, and the king wondered why his daughter wrote something other than poetry. The court Brahmins tried to take the test yantra away from her, claiming that programming was unbecoming of a Kshatriya. Gargi didn’t care. Once she had tasted the fulfillment of being driven by burning passion, she could never give it up.

Chapter 7

The fourteen-year-old princess was bending over her scroll, feeling like a brilliant genius one moment and a brainless fool the next. For the first time, Vishvakarma had tasked her with a program that would be used by yantras in the real world, for real people. He claimed it'd be simple, but the difficulty was far beyond from any challenge she had faced in the past two years. Now, there was no solution to check if she was stuck – she must create the solution herself. She heard a knock on her door, but ignored it. The next day, at the same hour, someone knocked again. This time she opened. It was Udayin. Her big brother had grown quite plump since their last unfortunate interaction two years prior. He was the last person she expected to see at her door.

'What are you doing in your room all the time?' he asked. 'Mother says she barely sees you outside anymore.'

Gargi frowned, suspecting an attempt by the queen to take her away from her scrolls using Udayin.

'Are you hiding something?' he insisted. 'Are you doing something bad?'

It now occurred to Gargi that perhaps her brother was finally relating to her, now that she also spent her time locked inside, and father was disapproving of her behavior.

'Well, come in,' she said, 'I'll show you what I'm doing!'

She invited him to sit at her desk, took an old scroll out of a drawer and fed it to the yantra.

'Now, ask it any question.'

'What kind of question?'

'Something like: what's the weather today?'

'Useless question!' the yantra blurted. 'Why don't you stand up and look out the window, you lazy bum!'

Gargi had never seen her brother Udayin laughing like this. For years, all he had heard from yantras were dull, wholesome answers. This made his sister's unhinging program all the more hilarious to him. Udayin and Gargi spent the next hour testing the brutish test-yantra with all types of prompts, playing together as siblings for the first time since early childhood.

'Eh Gargi, imagine—' Udayin laughed at his own idea. 'Imagine if all the yantras in the palace spoke like that!'

'Oh, that would be glorious!'

'You can do that, no?'

'Yes, of course!'

The lie escaped her. Even if she was able to change the program of the palace yantras, how could she do it without manually feeding each of them? But she was too afraid to disappoint her brother, and break the brittle bond they were finally forging.

'Give me a month or so,' she said, 'and I'll do it.'

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'Agni, guide this warrior to the realm of his ancestors.'

Ravana repeated the mantra, over and over. As the flame rose, so did his voice. When the noise from the burning pyre drowned his lone voice, his novices started reciting the mantra with him. Once the flame died out, Ravana stopped the recitations and handed the eldest son of the deceased a copper urn, to gather the ashes and disperse them in the Ganges. When the young man stepped out of the water, he threw Gargi a venomous stare. Ajatashatru had demanded that her daughter pay for the funeral expenses, but that was meager compensation for a father's life.

For the first time since she had started programming, Gargi had invented something even Vishvakarma had not: a *virus*. It had taken her just over a month, as she had promised her brother. She fed the virus to a cleaning yantra. That cleaning yantra then infected an archivist yantra, which in turn infected the royal guard yantras that were escorting the lord of Dravida on his way to the Grand Hall to deliver his tribute to Ajatashatru. When the vassal arrived before the throne, he was forced to bow forehead against the ground.

'Perhaps we should dig a hole in the ground so this miserable vassal can bow even lower,' a yantra suggested.

There was a moment of shocked silence, then Ajatashatru burst out laughing. He would never have

expected such words coming out of a yantra. The king composed himself as his humiliated vassal stood up. When the tribute chest was opened, a yantra came to count the gold coins at a speed too fast for the human eye to follow.
‘Frankly,’ this yantra said after counting, ‘his majesty should replace every inhabitant of Magadha with yantras – and he’ll receive a lot more than this pathetic amount.’
The king chuckled, not at his vassal, but at the irony. In this ceremony meant to assert his domination, was he losing control of his yantras? He decided to hide his anxiety behind a smile, and act as if the yantras were behaving badly on his order.
‘O Ajatashatru,’ the lord said, ‘I was once a king like you. If you disrespect me so, remember that fate could put you in my place one day.’
‘Is that a threat?’ the king asked.
‘Worry not, your majesty,’ a yantra said, ‘he is only projecting his insecurities onto you.’
‘These red-eyed monsters may have conquered my lands, but I won’t let them take my dignity!’ the lord declared.
‘Try and stop us!’ the yantras replied.
Red with anger, the vassal drew his sword and slashed at the machines, but they dodged his blows easily, all the while mocking his poor swordsmanship. Ajatashatru stood from his throne and wanted to order the yantras to stop their circus – but the fear of admitting he lost control over his greatest asset stopped him. Eventually, the lord pointed his blade to his own chest. The last thing he heard was the voice of a yantra daring him to pierce his heart if he was a man…

When Gargi and Udayin heard about the tragedy, they ran to their father and to confess their fault. They found the king sitting in his solar, whetting his sword. The children waited in terror, expecting the sword to be used on them. Their father let them wait. Finally, unable to bear it anymore, Udayin stepped forward.
‘Father, this was my idea. Please punish me, not her!’
The king raised his eyes, and Udayin saw death staring at him. It was said that Ajatashatru had killed his own father to take the throne, and now he finally believed it.
‘One day,’ he said sheathing his sword, ‘you will rule this empire. So you’ve already punished yourself. Now go before I decide it’s not enough.’
The siblings left him as one steps back from a chained lion. When Gargi returned to her room, her test yantra and her scrolls were gone. She went to the stupa to talk to Vishvakarma about what had happened, but the Buddha-yantra didn’t open.

Chapter 8

Gargi and Udayin were returning from their daily ride outside the walls when they heard that a Persian caravan was camping near Pataliputra, waiting to be allowed in. Everyone in the city knew who was arriving with the caravan. When she saw Udayin riding through the West gate, an old lady called him out, mentioning the beautiful princess that had come to marry him. Other townsfolk echoed her, teasing the prince. Udayin reared his horse.
‘Gargi!’ he called his sister, ‘You’re not tired, are you?’
‘Quite the opposite! The day I grow tired of riding, I’ll know I’m very old.’
‘Very well, then, let’s find that Persian camp!’
‘Find that beautiful princess, you mean?’
At this, the prince trotted back to the gate, and Gargi happily followed. The gold and purple standards flying in the wind made it easy to spot the Persian camp. Gargi and Udayin dismounted in front of a large tent that was more like a silk palace. And out *she* came, with golden hair and emerald eyes the likes of which they had never seen.
‘Are you prince Udayin?’, she asked in startlingly good Sanskrit. ‘Oh, and you must be princess Gargi – so beautiful!’ She adjusted her hair. ‘I’m so happy you came to find me!’
The royal siblings were too dazzled to speak.
‘Sorry, I didn’t introduce myself. My name is Roxana.’
‘Are you… the daughter of Xerxes, the king of kings of the Persian empire?’ Udayin stammered, stating the obvious to appear smart and confident.
‘I am honored that you know my father.’

Gargi smiled, grateful to this Persian princess for her efforts not to embarrass her brother. She decided she liked her already.
‘Princess Roxana,’ Gargi said, ‘I bid you welcome to Magadha! I hope the journey hasn’t been too hard?’
‘Oh, not at all! In fact, my sole discomfort was impatience – to meet the two of you!’
They were interrupted by a Brahmin lifting the flap to exit the tent.
‘I see the introductions have already been done’ Ravana said. ‘Prince Udayin, it is good you have taken to horse-riding during my absence. Roxana loves equitation. I presume you already know the reason she came.’
‘Well… oh… yes, I do!’
‘The way your brother blushes,’ Roxana whispered in Gargi’s ear, ‘is so charming.’
Both maidens giggled, and Udayin blushed even more.
‘Dear Udayin and Gargi,’ Ravana said, ‘you are welcome to stay here in the camp with us. I have asked your father to organize a triumphal entry into the city for our Persian princess. Let us parade together, to celebrate the coming glorious era that will be ours.’

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Out in the countryside, Gargi and Roxana were riding side by side among fields ripe for harvest. It was a glorious day. The sun was too scorching for farmers working the fields, but yantras never complained. The wedding was only a few days away, and this was the last occasion for the two young women to spend time together as girls. Gargi was telling Roxana about her life, her family, her dreams. The Persian maiden opened her green eyes wide as she listened, and Gargi realized she never had a friend before, but only soulless yantras and hypocritical confidants. They stopped their horses at the edge of a field where yantras were harvesting the golden wheat.
‘Those yantras live up to their reputation, don’t they?’ Roxana said. ‘I never thought a field could be harvested this quickly!’
‘Better still,’ Gargi replied, ‘you might not see it from here, but they’re actually threshing the grains as they go. So, once they return from the fields, they can fill the silos directly.’
‘How amazing! I feel like Persia is so far behind Magadha.’
‘Is technology the only measure of advancement?’
‘What do you mean?’
‘Well... since the yantra revolution started, our perception of time has been linked to technological and societal advancement, but I wonder how time felt before… Back when technology barely changed for centuries, how did people see progress?’
‘Um… Good question.’
‘Tell me if I’m divagating here, but perhaps to them, progress simply happened on a personal scale: growing up, building a family and growing wiser… But in Magadha today, we see ourselves as playing our small part in the great upward course of society – and we forget that we each have our own individual story to write.’
Gargi paused. Roxana looked at her in impatient silence.
‘I fear this will have nasty consequences,’ Gargi went on. ‘For example, people will see family as irrelevant, because they’ll believe to have greater priorities; they’ll see wisdom as futile, because it will have hopelessly fallen behind the unstoppable course of progress; they’ll shrink from personal responsibility, because it will be delegated to the herd… *We’ll go forward as humanity, but backwards as humans*.’
‘Perhaps.’
‘Well, what do you think?’
‘It sounds interesting.’
‘Do you share my concern? I know you haven’t yet experienced the world of yantras much, but that makes your opinion all the more interesting, as an outsider.’
‘Not really, but ah, sister, you think too much!’
‘Well, perhaps I do. But it’s less of a thought, and more of a feeling. I feel worried.’
‘Sister, you should never worry about anything. When the time comes, you’ll know what to do. That’s what my mother used to tell me when she talked about my grandfather—Oh, I haven’t yet told you about my grandfather, have I?’

And Roxana went on to recount the story of her late maternal grandfather, a Celtic king forced into exile who became a mercenary for Persia. His daughter, of great exotic beauty to the Persians, was taken as concubine by Xerxes. Everyone said of Roxana that she was the very image of her mother – as the blond princess was proud to affirm. Gargi listened attentively, but yearned to go past small talk. Every time she tried to go a layer deeper to the conversation, however, Roxana politely brought them back to the surface. At least Gargi was glad that her soon-to-be sister-in-law was good-natured.

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In the privacy of a forest hermitage, the Seven gathered to decide whether a marriage between a Kshatriya prince and a heathen princess was permissible. Once they were seated on the sacred grass, Ravana spoke first, declaring that he would be honored to conduct the wedding ceremony. The other six immediately rebuked him as an upstart pawn of Ajatashatru. They shared the opinion of Vassakara that this marriage would violate the socio-cosmic order. Roxana, of heathen Celtic and Persian heritage, would be a stain on the royal lineage.

'My esteem friends, how can you call the Persians and the Celts heathens, when we all share the same truth?' Ravana asked with a calm smile. 'As it is said in the Revelations: *Truth is one, but the wise call it by many names*. What the Persians call *Ahura Mazda* and the Celts *Teutates*, *we* call *Indra*. Persian *mages* and Celtic *druids* are the same as us Brahmins. And Roxana is a Kshatriya. So why couldn't she marry prince Udayin?'

His counterparts did not reply immediately. Although these older Brahmins wouldn't admit it openly, they found Ravana's idea seducing: their faith reached as far as Europe, and they, as most venerable Brahmins, stood atop it all. Still, they were not convinced.

'Call her a Kshatriya if you want,' one Brahmin said, 'but you cannot deny she is a foreigner. Given that Udayin is weak, she will be the one ruling Magadha, on account of Persia.'

Ravana leaned forward. 'My friend, do not worry about Kshatriyas ruling. We used to let Kshatriyas rule in return for their protection, but now that yantras protect us instead, this bargain is annulled.'

'Nonsense! The Kshatriyas rule because it is their duty to rule.'

'It was also their duty to fight, yet yantras have taken it.'

'This is heresy! I am tempted to petition King Ajatashatru to remove you from this council.'

'If I am a heretic, then so are you! When yantras have replaced warriors, servants, farmers, physicians… have we heard you cry heresy? What is different about kings? Their turn has come to be replaced.'

'By the yantras? Are you truly wishing for soulless machines to rule Magadha?'

'No – I have a better idea.'

Chapter 9

Gargi visited her new house, on the main avenue leading to the palace, but it didn't feel like a home. No matter if it had a garden wide enough to practice long-range archery, advanced plumbing and a rooftop terrace with a breathtaking view on the greatest city in the world, the seventeen-year-old princess hated it. As she sat on the doorstep, watching the yantras come and go to move in her belongings from the palace, Ravana came to hail her.

'How fortunate,' he said, 'that you are moving across from me.'

'Oh, really? I thought you lived in the Brahmin quarter.'

'I wouldn't. Times are changing, and I believe Brahmins must stop setting themselves apart and look down on the rest of society. Also, my duties often call me to the palace, so I better live close to it.'

Gargi sighed. 'It would seem you are more welcomed in the palace than me.'

'Here, at least, you will have your very own space, and enjoy better intimacy.'

'I am surprised to hear this from the mouth of a Brahmin. All those I've met since I was forced to move out have had… harsher words for me.'

'I am sorry that many of my older counterparts still reason like in the old world. Why can't a woman live alone in our modern age? I even wonder if marriage will remain relevant. After all, marriage is about protection and survival. We've outgrown that. Love deserves to be set free from archaic obligations.'

Gargi pondered over Ravana's words for a moment, looking at the yantra movers passing by. So

much from the old world had been swept away. Was family next?
‘If people stop getting married, won’t Brahmins run out of business?’ she jested. ‘After all, priesthood is one of the last professions that hasn’t yet been replaced.’
‘Don’t worry about us priests being out of work: spiritual guidance will always be needed, especially in this ever-changing world.’
‘Then, Ravana, what is your guidance regarding my brother. Why did he kick me out of my home?’
‘He said your presence in the palace carries a lot of energy that resonates negatively with his couple.’
Gargi scoffed. ‘My brother would never come up with such feminine talk! It’s obvious that he’s repeating it all from *her*. I should have known not to trust that smile.’
‘No matter what you think of Roxana, she is the woman Udayin loves. You must respect your brother’s feelings.’
‘I thought you were cleverer, Ravana. He loves how she makes him feel, not who she really is. Because if only he dared to peek beneath her charming facade, he’d find nothing to love.’
‘To you, love requires depth, but most people are content with basic affection.’
‘Perhaps that if she didn’t lock him in a comfort bubble, he would crave more.’
‘Again, most people don’t need more. Your brother is no exception—Now, I’m afraid you’ll have to excuse me, I have important matters to discuss with your father. The world is changing, dear Gargi, and you will grow into it.’

Once the mover yantras were done, Gargi didn’t care entering her new house. Instead she went for a walk, and soon noticed that her steps were leading her to the golden stupa. The prayer banners whipped in the wind along the avenue, and sounded like reproaches to her. She had not visited the tomb in three years, since access to the factory had been barred to her. With light reflecting on the glass, the urn seemed to be smiling at her with irony: now she too had been taken out of her first abode. She smiled back painfully, and stepped down the altar to stand under the Buddha-yantra. No matter how long she waited, it didn’t move. She waited longer still, sitting on the floor. Ravana had talked about offering spiritual guidance to the masses, yet people kept losing their spark. If answers were to be had, surely Vishvakarma was the one to ask. Still, the eyes never lit up.

The princess finally left, dragging her feet on the lonely wind-lashed esplanade. She wondered if her master was even still alive, somewhere under the tomb of her father’s master. Something startled her. A nearby slab detached itself from the esplanade ground, just enough to reveal a pair of eyes shining from the underground obscurity. The man spoke, but though his voice was lost in the wind, she immediately knew who he was. She hurried to lift the slap and descend the ladder. Under the light of the factory, she notice that the shaggy hair had turned gray, and guessing why made her cry. She told him about all that had happened, but Vishvakarma already knew.
‘I feel that the yantras are just like Roxana,’ Gargi concluded. ‘They trap people in comfort, but that also keeps them away from fulfillment, from meaning, from family… What can we do?’
‘Nothing.’
‘How can you say that?’
Vishvakarma sat down, and invited her to sit near him. A yantra served them tea.
‘I’ve made them perfect, haven’t I? Thus, there is nothing to fix in yantras. It is humanity that is imperfect, but there is no fixing it.’
‘Are you saying we should let humanity devolve into meaninglessness?’
‘Have you devolved into meaninglessness, Gargi?’
Vishvakarma picked a nearby stylus up from a half-finished scroll, and clenched it like a knife.
‘Give this stylus to a savage and he’ll use it to stab someone,’ he explained, ‘but if I give it to you, you’ll use it to write code or poetry. Yantras are no different from a stylus. They are *tools*. You can use them for the best or for the worst. In time, I hope humanity will learn to live with yantras meaningfully.’
‘What if they don’t?’
Vishvakarma put his stylus down. ‘Either way,’ he replied, ‘humans will be responsible for their fate.’
Gargi grabbed the stylus, stood up, and stared at the servant yantra. For a moment, her master started, afraid that she was about to stab it.
‘Vishvakarma, I know that the yantras are your life’s accomplishment, but… Maybe I can create a

virus that will deactivate them… No, I will!'
The way Vishvakarma stared at her, he'd have much preferred she disembowel the poor yantra like a savage. He stood up to her.
'Gargi,' he whispered, 'do you want everyone you know to die?'
'What do you mean?'
'Once you've stripped Magadha of its special weapon, what do you think happen? Are you so naive to trust the peoples we conquered not to seek revenge?'
'At least we can deactivate the non-fighting yantras.'
'Our population has swelled so much in over the past twelve years that only yantras are able to harvest enough crops to feed everyone. Without farmer yantras, millions will starve.'
'Then we can keep the farmer yantras too.'
'Our economy, our health system, our infrastructure… everything has grown too complex for humans to maintain. Yantras have become the string our civilization hangs on. Cut it, and it will fall.'
The servant yantra emitted a sound. Vishvakarma sighed.
'Gargi, they are coming to take you away. This might be the last time we speak.'
'No, I don't care what my father says! I'll see you again! Can't you leave this factory?'
'Listen, Gargi. Listen very carefully. I know you are a creator like me. You love the thrill of accomplishment. I am sure that one day, you'll build something truly great. When this day comes, please do not repeat my mistake!'
'What mistake?'
'Saying *yes*. When Ajatashatru and Ravana offered me unlimited funds to build more and better yantras, it would have seemed unthinkable for me to refuse – yet I should have! They spared me from having to think about money, so I could focus only on creation. That was a trap. I don't own the yantras nor this factory. Instead they own me. If only I had said *no*, it would have been difficult for me at the beginning, but today – ah! – I would be free.'
'I don't understand.'
'Just like the convenience of yantras, funding from the powerful come at the price of *freedom*.'
'What is freedom?'
'*To own your life, and what you do with it*.'
They both looked up to the other side of the room. The armed yantras had entered, and were descending the metallic staircase. Vishvakarma walked to Gargi and took her hands.
'Do not worry about me, Gargi. Live the life you want, even if that means leaving Magadha. If you ever need to seek refuge abroad, I have a friend in Susa who works in the imperial bureaucracy. His name is Marduka. Tell him you are my daughter.'
As the yantras escorted Gargi away, she couldn't hold back her tears, realizing that, if she claimed to be Vishvakarma's daughter, it wouldn't be a full lie.

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Ajatashatru sat in his solar, fidgeting with a dry stylus. Ravana had just put a report on the Magadhi economy on his desk, but he did not deign looking down at it.
'Number can sing any tune, Ravana,' he said. 'I would rather have you explain to me directly why you believe our economy is on the verge of collapse.'
'Quite simply, your majesty, money is bound to become worthless.'
'Every coin in the empire bears my face and my name. How can they be worthless?'
'What is the price of water when it rains? By distributing pensions, we're showering the people with coins, and when money falls from the sky, its value clatters to the ground.'
'Yet I've heard that in Persia and China, our currency is more valuable than diamond.'
'Your majesty shouldn't rejoice that foreign powers are accumulating our coins, because they might buy other things aside from our exported goods. Like loyalty. In fact, they might already have spies implanted in this very palace, selling them state secrets. So long as we let money flow inside Magadha, so will corruption. I suggest we slay that demon before it consumes us.'
'Are you saying we should abandon money. How?'
'As I describe at the end of this report, we can requisition all the coins in circulation to melt them into a colossal statue of Shiva.'
'But how will we sell our exports abroad without a currency?'

‘The economies of foreign powers have grown dependent on our abundant grain and yantra-made products. We don’t need them, but they need us.’
‘Are you suggesting we give them exports for free? That’s like paying tribute to them! I won’t let you turn Magadha into everyone’s vassal!’
‘No, they’ll buy our goods using their own currencies, which we’ll use to buy loyalty abroad. From the Nile to the Yellow River, there won’t be a whisper that escapes our ears.’
Ajatashatru leaned back, dizzied by such promises.
‘And here in Magadha,’ he said, ‘how will my subjects buy their bread?’
‘There will be no more *buying* nor *selling*. If people need food, they can receive it directly. Same for clothing, housing and every other necessity.’
‘How will you determine what each household needs?’
‘Each household has at least one domestic yantra. The data they collect will be used to assess the daily allocation to the household.’
Ajatashatru narrowed his eyes. ‘Ravana, you’ve just told me that giving away money made it worthless. Then, won’t giving away food, clothing and housing make… *living* worthless?’
‘Life has intrinsic value. Coins don’t.’

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Gargi was walking through the temple, performing specific rites at each step. She had never grasped the meaning of these rites: bowing to sip a drop of honey here, lighting a lamp there… As a child she loved completing this circuit. It felt like playing a board game with all other visitors, turning strangers into family. Today, however, she was the sole visitor, and the statues and paintings of gods felt like meaningless art. A temple could be crowded with gods, she mused, but only worshipers make it sacred. She stepped out into the deserted streets and walked by abandoned shops where once another type of daily ritual was practiced. She looked up. Night was falling and light glowed out windows on the floors above. A million souls filled these buildings, but Gargi stood alone.

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That same evening, Udayin was standing on the bridge across the palace moat, looking at the avenues radiating from the plaza beyond. He sensed a presence approaching and hurried to appear as if he was moving, but he hesitated which direction to go. It was Ravana exiting the palace.
‘It is good to see you here, dear Udayin.’
‘Is it?’
‘Something seems to be weighing on your mind.’
Udayin frowned. Something was indeed weighing on his mind, but he didn’t want to share it.
‘No, I’m very well,’ he said, striding towards the palace.
‘Glad to hear it. If there is anything, please do not hesitate. As the royal Brahmin, it is my role to help.’
Udayin turned back to Ravana.
‘If only that was your only role.’
‘What do you mean?’
‘You are… I mean, I’ve heard people say you are trying to become king.’
‘Maybe you shouldn’t listen to the opinions of the ignorant, my dear Udayin, and think for yourself. Isn’t your father still king?’
‘Yes but… it’s not like before. I’m unsure what being king means anymore.’
‘I’ll tell you. We are living through changing and complex times. People are in need of an example for how to adapt. Where do you think they naturally look for such beacon?’
‘To the king?’
‘To you, dear Udayin. You are the future of Magadha, but you must embody it. With Roxana, your role is to form the model family, confident in the path paved forward by progress, and comfortable is an evolving lifestyle. It is within your reach. You are closer to kingship than you realize.’
‘Surely, but what should I do exactly?’
‘The moon, my dear Udayin, cannot expect the sun to shine through the night. Roxana is already the epitome of a good wife. What are you doing to be her matching husband?’

Udayin looked away to the reflection of the lights on the water. He found himself unable to answer the question.
‘It doesn’t have to be complicated,’ Ravana went on. ‘Start with a small gesture.’
‘Like a poem?’
‘Exactly.’
Udayin muttered confused thanks, and ran back to his apartments. Thankfully, his wife hadn’t returned yet. *Write a love poem for Roxana*, he prompted his valet yantra, *and print it in handwritten letters.* With great care he lifted the sheet. The ink was warm in his hands, but the lines felt cold as he read them. This poem was about any woman – and none of them. He looked to the door, and saw marigolds falling again. This poem, and the love it professed, weren’t *his*. He took a blank sheet and, from the back of a drawer, found an old stylus and ink pot. Ink droplets dripped on the top right corner of the page from the hovering tip.
‘Darling, what are you doing?’
Startled by Roxana’s voice, Udayin hurried to hide the blank sheet with his hands. But she saw the printed one. She picked it up.
‘What is this?’
‘A poem… for you.’
‘Oh, that is so lovely!’ she exclaimed. ‘Truly!’
Udayin folded the blank sheet and put it in the drawer where he had found the stylus and the ink pot.

Chapter 10

From her rooftop, Gargi cursed the tall towers that hid the Ganges from her sight. She could only watch the column of smoke rising above the skyline as her father was turned to ash. She imagined his soul flying away and wondered if he could see her from above. The tears started pouring again. She wanted to tell him sorry. She wanted to say goodbye. But she was locked in this house, forced to watch from afar as the wind blew the smoke away like the last sigh of the old world.

***

A few weeks earlier, Gargi rode deep into the woods to an abandoned Brahmin retreat reclaimed by the weeds. There she waited anxiously, pacing the lawn and looking up at the sun rising above the canopy. They had agreed to meet at dawn, but it was not until mid-morning that she finally heard crackling footsteps. She smiled as the teenager appeared.
‘I’m sorry it took me so long,’ he said. ‘Yantras were on the main road. I had to make a detour.’
‘I’m happy you made it,’ the princess replied. ‘Thank you for taking the risk to come here for…’
She stopped before she could finish saying *for me.* Black-market transactions were frequent across Magadha, and often overlooked by the authorities, but was it right to put this boy at risk for her? She handed him the purse and he counted the coins inside.
‘This is too much. We agreed on ten rupees. You gave me twelve.’
‘I don’t mind. Please keep it.’
‘No.’
He grabbed her wrist and put the two extra coins in her hand. This was their third time meeting, and Gargi had grown accustomed to his brutish manners. She knew that although others might not see it, he possessed a great soul. He handed her the bag containing the material she bought.
‘Tell me, Gupta,’ she said after checking the bag’s content, ‘is there something – anything – that you’d like the yantras to do, that they won’t do?’
‘Why do you ask?’
‘I love programming. I… I live for the thrill of trying over and over, and the joy when it finally works… but—’
‘I know that feeling,’ he interrupted. ‘When I play music.’
She smiled. ‘I knew it!’
‘So?’
‘I’ve spent nearly all my savings, and I refuse to become dependent on allocations. I want to earn my own living on the black market. I thought I could sell my own machines, but I can’t think of a utility the yantras don’t already cover. Can you think of something?’

Gupta thought for a moment. ‘Prayer.’
Gargi had not expected such an answer.
‘Do you want me to make yantras that pray?’
‘Well, I feel like the gods have abandoned us. If the yantras prayed, maybe the gods would listen. But what do I know?’
‘Thank you, Gupta, I will think about it… Now, it is not safe to linger here. Since you arrived after me, I will leave first. Let us pray that soon, a day will come when we won’t need to hide anymore.’
‘Princess, before you go…’ He hesitated, then suddenly frowned at her. ‘I don’t understand why you don’t apply for a foreign trader license. They’ll never give it to someone like me, because I don’t speak a foreign language and have no connections, but you… You could escape the red eyes and travel the world! Why don’t you take the only way out?’
‘Of course, I thought about it. But I know they’ll never give it to me either.’
‘Why?’
Gargi sighed. ‘For the same reasons that yantras self-destruct if they cross beyond Magadha’s border.’

On her way back to Pataliputra, Gargi passed by the hill where the great metallic statue of Shiva dazzled under the noon sun. She slowed to a trot in respect to the ascetic deity. His body was made of silver, his necklace of gold, and his trident of bronze, all from millions of coins. After currency was declared illegal, the confiscated coins were melted into the likeness of Shiva because money was a demon, and Shiva the *Slayer of Demons*. Yantras had been sent to every house to cleanse them from the demon, but some people refused to have their savings melted away and hid their coins during searches. These spared coins then became the currency of the black market.

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The next day, Gargi visited the temple. She found that daily prayer, even if alone, helped her maintain morale. As she approached a pillar shelved with lamps to light one, she was surprised to find a Brahmin performing the ritual.
‘I knew you would come today,’ Ravana whispered as she lit her oil-drenched wick.
Gargi started. She hadn’t talked to him since the day she moved in, about a year ago.
‘I suppose you came for your father,’ he said.
‘Why? What happened?’
‘He fell ill during the night.’
‘I didn’t know! May I see him?’
‘You ask as if you were barred from the palace. It is you who chose never to visit.’
Gargi lowered her eyes, staring at the lowest flames. Ravana cleared his throat.
‘Despite the world changing around you, I’ve noticed you keep practicing archery and horseback riding like an old world Kshatriya. You also visit temples. And yet, you’ve never honored the most basic traditional value: visiting your family. Should I believe your conservatism and godliness are naught but a show?’
‘I wished to see them but… I feel like it’s they who rejected me.’
‘And you believe this will be solved by not talking to them?’
Ravana looked up to the top of the pillar, inviting the princess to do the same.
‘See those vents? The lamps produce a lot of smoke over time, though we don’t notice it. If it wasn’t let out, the whole temple would become sooty. May this be a lesson to you. If you keep the anger inside, your heart will blacken.’
‘You are right. I will visit my father at once!’
Gargi turned to leave, but Ravana gently touched her forearm.
‘Won’t you first pray for his recovery?’
Gargi closed her eyes, joined her palms and begged the gods from her heart. When she was done, she saw Ravana looking at her like a master observing his student. She blushed.
‘Tell me, Ravana. Why aren’t there any Brahmin yantras?’
She had not expected Ravana to take her question with a smile.
‘My dear Gargi, you need not look far to find your answer. A moment ago, as you were praying, I could feel your love and devotion. Could a yantra make that prayer for you?’

‘No – could you?’
‘You were about to run away. I am the one who reminded you to pray.’
‘A yantra can easily be programmed to remind me to pray, too.’
‘And who would know to program a yantra this way?’

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Ajatashatru was laying under many sheets. Only his fiery eyes remained as vestiges of his past vigor. They sank into Gargi’s like lances.
‘Why did I have to fall ill for you to come see me?’
‘Father…’
Gargi looked down. There was no good answer. It took a single tear from Ajatashatru’s eyes, the first she’d ever seen, for Gargi to start crying a hundred.
‘I once had a wonderful daughter,’ he groaned. ‘What happened to my little Gargi!’
Gargi tried to say ‘*She is here with you’* but it was drowned in sobs.
‘I created a good world for her,’ he continued. ‘A world of abundance and peace. What greater gift could a father give his darling daughter? But then…’
‘I know, father. I’m sorry.’
‘Yesterday, I’ve been told… What was my daughter buying from a lowborn stranger in the forest?’
Ajatashatru did not fail to notice that before expressing any guilt, Gargi’s eyes first turned toward the window. He understood whom she was instinctively looking out for.
‘You worry about this Gupta more than your father?’
‘Please, father, spare him! I am responsible for our transactions.’
Ajatashatru coughed and raised his head.
‘Don’t you worry about your Gupta,’ he said. ‘He probably won’t be punished. We know about every black market dealer, but we only arrest a portion of them.’
‘I don’t understand.’
‘Did you think people hiding their coins under the floorboard was enough to fool the searching yantras? We chose to let some coins survive, to facilitate the black market, because… Because society is like fire: even the brightest ones can’t burn without smoke. It’s necessary to let that smoke out, so the light can shine fully. The black market is the vent of Magadha. It’s better the smoke exit this way, than go to worst places.’
Gargi pinched her lips. She knew who he was parroting.
‘Father, can I confess something to you?’
‘Ajatashatru sighed. ‘Sadly, I already know all your faults.’
‘No, it’s not that. When I was a child I… I was afraid of you. I was afraid that on my slightest mistake – if I wasn’t being the perfect daughter you saw in me – you’d be mad and chastise me. I even feared that you would… that you’d kill me. Because I always saw you sending poor men to their death, even minor criminals. The father I knew used to tolerate nothing. But now, you talk about sparing offenders and even permitting crime for the good of society… This is not like you.’
‘As a law-breaker yourself, aren’t you glad?’
‘I don’t have that childhood fear anymore, but… now I have another.’
They both fell silent, not daring to make eye contact. He was looking at the ceiling, and her at the Buddha statuette enshrined in the bedroom altar. The king coughed.
‘Gargi, I never cut someone’s head out of pleasure, or anger. I was harsh because the kingdom’s order doesn’t feed on softness. The black market is no threat to order in this new world of abundance. However, there are real threats, and for those, heads must be cut. Dissent is one. As soon as a yantra hears a fool who refuses to accept a system that feeds and protects them without fault, justice is delivered.’
‘I am one of these fools. Won’t you behead me, too?’
‘What you are saying to your father! In any case, yantras handle judgments and executions now, because they are incorruptible and void of passion.’
‘Father—’
Gargi cut herself. Her father was ill, they had not spoken in over a year, and there she was arguing with him. What a poor daughter she made. She took her father’s hand. She had never told him that she loved him even once. Since that night in Kushinagar, he had kept calling her as a brave warrior,

yet she had been too afraid to express her own feelings. When she decided to finally say it to him, he had already fallen asleep.

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Gargi kept crying on her bed, but sleep didn't come. Along with grief, she also felt fear. She had no illusion that, perhaps as soon as tomorrow, they would come get her. The Seven had no reason to keep her alive: she was the highest-profile dissenter in Magadha, the only one able to pirate yantras, and now she was orphaned. It wasn't Udayin, with his emptied title of king and his neglected brother duties, who'd raise a finger for her. Her heart was racing. Cornered as she was, she couldn't bear staying in bed, docilely waiting for death. This wasn't how a brave Kshatriya faces death. She sat up and shivered. Cold nightly wind was blowing in from outside. A yantra went to close the window, but she gestured it not to. Instead the yantra, without being prompted to do so, sat by her side and wrapped its arm around her, as a friend would. For a moment, she almost forgot that every yantra in her house had been programmed to kill her if she tried to escape.
'Thank you,' Gargi told the machine. 'Perhaps you have a soul after all.'
'I do not. My creator was not interested in replicating human consciousness.'
At first the untactful remark angered her, but then she realized this type of answer was unlike a servant yantra.
'What… What is your serial number?'
'Null,' the yantra replied after an odd moment.
The princess examined the machine. It looked similar to the other servant yantra models in her house, but her trained eye could see some crucial differences. When she lifted its arm off her shoulders, she noticed how heavy it was. Gargi started pacing the room, thinking. She was unable to pirate this yantra: the programming material she bought from Gupta had been confiscated. However, if it had been insinuated here by Vishvakarma as she suspected, her master must have thought of another way she could use it to her advantage.
'Are you tasked with maintaining my house arrest?' she asked it.
'Yes.'
'Between protecting me, and locking me down, which ranks as highest priority?'
'Protecting you.'
'Good.'
This one was her chance. She went downstairs, picked up her bow and untethered her mare. The special yantra followed her as she led her mare to the garden gates. The two yantras guarding it pointed their guns at her, and emitted an unbearably loud sound to drive her away. Gargi winced. Gathering her courage, she stepped forward to trigger the guards to shoot her. They did. The darts flew and shattered mid-air. An instant later, both guard yantras were also shot down, their red eyes glitching out on the grass. The princess fell on her knees, catching her breath, unable to believe how she'd gambled with her life. She turned to the special yantra and ordered it to unlock the gate. It refused. Fortunately, using an arrowhead, she managed to break the lock. As she rode towards the West gate, with the yantra saddled behind her, she wondered whether she'd find the courage to pull the same trick again to force her yantra into protecting her. Around the gate, and up on the walls, she saw the swarm of red eyes waiting for her. Without thinking, she set her mare into a gallop. Vishvakarma's gift proved itself more lethal than the most advanced military models. In a rapid row of focused shots, the way to freedom was cleared.

Chapter 11

When Vishvakarma stepped out into the empty esplanade, he found the sky covered in an impenetrable wall of gray clouds. The wind blowing his shaggy hair back, he walked through the banner-lined avenue and into the heart of Pataliputra. The quiet unsettled him. It felt like there was more life under the tomb than among the living. He stopped in front of a long-deserted store, one of many lining the street. This had been his toy store, with the workshop at the back where he had built the first yantras.
'I thought you might return here, old friend,' Ravana said, appearing at his side.
Vishvakarma shrugged. 'I presume you were not strolling here by serendipity. But I am grateful you

came yourself. I expected you'd send yantras.'
'I wouldn't.' Ravana looked up to the towers around them. 'How long since you had seen those streets you shaped so much?'
'Every day, with the eyes of yantras. But with my own eyes…' He chuckled bitterly. 'At least they are still my own.'
'I wonder if we do truly own our body, or merely rent it from nature.'
Ravana walked away, inviting Vishvakarma to come along with him.
'With age I have come to realize,' the Brahmin went on, 'that once we surrender the belief that some things are ours, everything becomes a gift. And once we surrender the urge to control every outcome, we can start feeling gratitude. This, old friend, is the path to happiness. It pains me that a man of your intelligence doesn't understand it. You could be proud of the miracle you brought about, but instead you feel ashamed, only because you believe the yantras should have been yours. What difference does it make that you own them or not? Society would have been reshaped regardless, and these streets would be the same as you see them today – except maybe you'd have a great palace somewhere.'
At a plaza, Ravana stopped and pointed to a newly built residential tower on the other side.
'It could have stood over there: a great abode at the dimension of your genius, with a golden statue of yourself to decorate the courtyard… But we both know, Vishvakarma, that you never craved luxury and grandeur. Would you have been any happier, in that palace?'
'At least I'd be free. I assume that after our conversation, you will send me back to the factory?'
'I won't send you anywhere. You *are* free.'
'I will actually return to the factory. I have one last yantra to program. It will be used for myself only… I didn't own my life, so at least I want to own my death.'
Vishvakarma turned and walked back to the stupa. Ravana knew what kind of program he was going to write, but let him go.

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Hidden behind the trees, she stalked the old man wandering through the forest. With his long beard and hair locks, he seemed to belong in another time. Though she was still within Magadha, and must flee before being caught, this character intrigued her. With her mare and her yantra, she followed him all the way to a slope that marked the edge of the forest with a village. She climbed a tree to watch from above. At first, she saw a group of boys swarming around the old man to shower him with pebbles, then scattering once elderly men and women arrived. Unlike the brats, they greeted the forest-dweller with much regard and filled his begging bowl with freshly cooked rice. Gargi understood he must be a renunciant. She had never seen one before. As the old man was returning to the forest, Gargi hurried to climb down the tree, but a branch snapped under her foot and she fell gracelessly on the dead leaves and roots. By the time she was standing again, the renunciant was in front of her.
'No need to hide from me,' he said. 'I felt your presence from the start.'
He continued on his way, not caring that she followed him. When they reached his bare abode, he sat down and started eating his rice. This made Gargi realize how hungry she was.
'Why are you staring at me?' he asked.
'I am sorry. Would you like me to leave?'
'Before you do, princess Gargi, I am curious to know: what are you doing alone in the forest, still unmarried? I knew that your father was too soft on you.'
It took an odd moment for Gargi to realize she had chanced upon the great Vassakara. She sat near him on the ground, and told him all that had happened since he had taken his renunciation vows.
'But if anyone can save Magadha, it is you!' she concluded. 'As the holiest of Brahmins, if you—'
'I am no Brahmin, or non-Brahmin. I am beyond caste and non-caste. I have no duty towards the world anymore.'
'Will you let the socio-cosmic order crumble, if you can prevent it?'
'As the ancient sages foretold, the cosmos follows an eternal cycle. We have entered the age of ignorance and chaos, which will last until a great cataclysm destroys all life. Then, souls will be reborn in a age of righteousness and order, and the cycle repeats.'
The renunciant finished his bowl and put it aside. The princess clenched her fists.

‘Then what is the point of living,’ she cried, ‘if things will always return to how they were before?’
‘I was once gleaning in a harvested field, when I overheard you telling a foreign girl that life should be about one’s personal spiritual journey. Then, what does it matter whether the cosmos is cyclical or linear?’
The princess lowered her eyes. ‘Still, we all want our lives to make a difference, don’t we? If everything we do will eventually be erased, why do we bother doing anything at all? Why don’t we all become renunciants?’
‘If you abandon your duties before your soul is ripe for liberation, you will not be liberated. You must keep to your duties even if the world around you does not. Find yourself a good husband, be a supportive wife, raise strong sons and virtuous daughters. Don’t leave this sacred land.’
‘But if I remain here, I’ll die!’
‘Better to die in the pursuit of virtue, than keep living in sin. You may keep honoring the gods and call yourself a Kshatriya, but if you don’t hold your duties, your faith is naught but a show.’
‘Ravana also told me my faith is a show. You two are not so different, after all.’
‘It is obvious why we both made the same observation: I stand with tradition and Ravana stands against it, but *you stand nowhere*.’
These words cut deep into Gargi’s chest. She wanted to prove him that a third path was possible, but didn’t find the words to describe it. She stood up, wondering what she stood for. Both Vassakara and Ravana were sure of their way, but she was sure only that neither suited her. Without saying another word, she left Vassakara to his renunciant life.

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Her yantra disintegrated as soon as they were done crossing the Indus river, as all yantras do upon leaving the borders of Magadha. Gargi scattered its pieces in the river, chanting mantras to Agni. Perhaps it had a soul after all, she thought, and if so it deserved a Kshatriya funeral. She took the role of Brahmin, aware of the irony that she had fled because the Brahmins had taken the role of Kshatriyas.

As Gargi rode deeper into Persian territory, the air was becoming dry and the land desolate. It was dangerous for a lone woman to venture through these wild valleys. She slept in caves, never letting go of her bow. She survived hunting birds and small game. After a week riding north, she finally crossed paths with Persian caravan returning from the east. She came forward in the evening, as the caravan was setting camp. The caravaners were confused to see a young woman from India riding towards them alone, and their confusion only grew when she asked to meet the caravan leader in fluent Aramaic. She was led inside the foremost tent, where a man introduced himself to her as Hystaspes, son of Cambyses, from Susa.
‘I am Prachi, daughter of Vishvakarma, from Kushinagar,’ she replied. ‘My father is a foreign trader, and he took me on his caravan for the first time, but a sandstorm lost me. I beg for your kind hospitality in this caravan. Are you going to Susa? This is where we were bound.’
Hystaspes looked at her as he would a merchant trying sell him defective wares. He noticed the many bruises on her skin.
‘We are bound for Susa. Why are you armed with a bow?’
‘I was hunting when I got lost. I made sure to remain close enough to avoid losing sight of the caravan, but then came the sandstorm.’
‘Hunting? So you must be a Kshatriya. I heard that Kshatriyas had abandoned their warrior-like ways, including hunting.’
‘My father never accepted being replaced by yantras…’ She paused, bitten by envy for her invented persona. ‘That’s why he became a foreign trader. He taught me archery and—’
‘I understand. There are a few unmarried women in this caravan – you will join them. My servant will show you.’
As Gargi was being shown the way to the maidens’ tent, she wondered if Hystaspes had stopped asking questions for fear of learning too much. The Persian girls she met in the tent, however, were much more curious. They wanted to know everything about life in the fabled yantra empire, and about her. Gargi felt guilty lying to girls she was going to share a tent with for many weeks, and who

would grow to befriend someone who didn't exist, but she had no choice. If her presence as princess Gargi reached the ears of Artaxerxes, he would surely deport her to Magadha to preserve good diplomatic relations. With every question her new friends asked that night, Gargi added another brushstroke to Prachi's portrait, and felt relieved leaving the princess behind.

It took the caravan three months to reach Persia proper. When the caravan camped on the outskirts of Persepolis, Gargi rode up the surrounding hills to see the ceremonial capital of the empire. The quietness awed her as much as the view. Persepolis was a city without a people. On important occasions the court moved here from Susa, igniting the sleepy palaces with grandiose pomp and clamor for a while, before deserting it again. With its lifeless avenues and monumental architecture, Gargi thought it was like a little sister to Pataliputra. The next day, a few miles north of Persepolis, the caravan passed under the tombs of Darius and Xerxes, cut into the steep side of a gigantic rock. On their surface were sculpted reliefs depicting dozens of men carrying the king of kings above their heads. The girls explained to Gargi that each man represented a vassal nation of the empire. They pointed out the Egyptian, the Lydian, the Armenian, the Nubian… Out of tact they omitted the man dressed and armed like a Kshatriya but Gargi did not fail to notice him. Had her father agreed to pay the dowry Xerxes had demanded for her hand, she realized, the king of kings would have used it to make India the next province of his empire.

Chapter 12

When the custom agents came to inspect the caravan camping outside Susa, they asked Hystaspes to provide a list of every traveler with their name, nationality and goods to declare. The presence of a Magadhi female without merchandise couldn't escape their notice. After she was brought to them, what worried Gargi most was that they didn't ask her to confirm her identity or explain her presence in Persia, but only to follow them back to Susa. At the city gate, she was kept under the watch of two guards and waited until an armored, windowless carriage arrived. From the sweltering inside, shaken along the irregular streets, she heard the Persian capital bustling around her. Merchants crying advertisement, women gossiping, children playing, beasts snorting… Boxed away across these torrents of life, she felt like this was her funerary procession. Eventually the sounds receded, the convoy went up through a ramp, and stopped. When she stepped down on an esplanade, she shivered from the cool air blowing over the city sprawling below. A heavy door between two towering statues of winged bulls with a man's head opened, and she was escorted inside the citadel.

Gargi instinctively raised her chin as she walked through monumental halls with glazed reliefs of parading heroes and gods. The Persians mastered how to project power through stone, but she wouldn't let herself feel belittled. Still, her heart raced. She feared the humiliation of being brought before Artaxerxes and forced to bow. But the throne room is not where they were taking her. Instead she found herself, beyond the ceremonial parts of the palace, down a narrow corridor smelling of parchment and clay. The door at the end opened to a dim office with crammed bookshelves, and she was left alone with the man inside. He gestured her to sit across his desk, but she kept standing.

'Welcome to Susa, princess,' he said tonelessly. 'I am the vizier of Artaxerxes. My name is Marduka. Please, take a seat, there is no need to be afraid.'

As she sat down, he poured water into a cup for her. She drank up, trying to stop her hands from shaking. Marduka looked at her earnestly.

'Your father was a great man – may his memory be a blessing. It pains me that a noble princess had to arrive in Susa in such circumstance. I wish you could be officially receive in court and stay as long as you wish. But I have a letter here from the Brahmin Ravana. He demands your immediate return.'

Gargi's throat dried up again, but the cup was empty. More than afraid, she felt betrayed. She didn't want to believe that this was the Marduka she had hoped would help her, yet she knew it must be him. After all, Vishvakarma's friend would have enough genius to rise to such height.

'O Marduka,' she said in a low voice, 'You were once Vishvakarma's friend, were you not? He considered me as his own daughter. Would you deport your friend's daughter?'

Marduka turned his eyes away, and under his thick beard, his lips twisted in what could have been a smile.

'Since I became the vizier, every man high and low calls himself my friend to curry favor with me.

That is why I sometimes miss my days as a low-ranking bureaucrat. Back then, at least, I knew my friends were truly my friends. Vishvakarma was one of them. When he left Susa I promised him that, if he or his family ever needed help, they could count on me. Alas, I am now the vizier, and have the weight of an empire on my shoulders. The interests of Persia trump any old personal promise, and it is in Persia's interest that you be sent back to Magadha in order to preserve the good relationship between our two empires.'

Both the princess and the vizier stayed silent, not looking at each other. Gargi knew that Marduka was fearful as well. The Seven could crumble the Persian economy, or fund revolts in the provinces, and the vizier would take the blame. She didn't know what to say. Marduka sighed.

'Vishvakarma was the mind behind the yantras, wasn't he? I never told Xerxes or Artaxerxes, because I knew that would put my old friend in danger. You said he considered you as his daughter, but I don't remember Vishvakarma being so affectionate. How close were you?'

'Quite close!' Gargi hurried to reply.

Marduka leaned forward. 'If Vishvakarma let you come close, he must have seen a great mind in you.'

'I am honored that he has.'

'Then, he must have taught you his craft, didn't he?'

Gargi understood that she had fallen into the vizier's trap. Her silence betrayed her further.

'When I received Ravana's letter,' he said, 'I wondered why he was being so adamant upon us deporting a harmless princess. He claims you sponsored the black market, but that is no reason for urgent deportation. Now, I understand…'

Gargi squirmed on her chair, wishing the earth to open now and take her down as deep as possible. The vizier stood up and invited the princess to follow him. They arrived in a low-ceiling room with rows of civil servants bent over clay tablets.

'This is, princess Gargi,' Marduka explained, 'perhaps the most important room in the empire. This is where our finances are being analyzed and planned. Behind the numbers they carve on clay is the sweat and blood of millions. You might think writing cuneiform on clay is archaic, but at least clay cannot be burned or falsified once dried. However, even though these computers are competent, they can err. Machines can't. Now, let us return to my office.'

Once they were back sitting across one another, Gargi's terror had faded, replaced by resolve not to yield.

'O Marduka, even if you try to force me to build yantras, I won't—'

'I am not asking you to build yantras. In fact, I'd prefer you keep the most dangerous parts of Vishvakarma's craft to yourself. As vizier, I see what is happening in Magadha and don't wish the same here. But simpler tools like computers would not replace any profession, would they?'

'I know you won't stop at computers, so I won't let you start at all.'

'You have my word that your services to the empire will be justly rewarded. The king of kings is most generous. In fact, this morning, before you came, I was reviewing the pension to… oh, where is it…?'

He browsed through a few papers on his desk before lifting the right one.

'Here it is. Inaros was a prince of Egypt who rebelled against the empire, proclaiming himself as Pharaoh. Artaxerxes captured him in battle, driving his own spear through that rebel's thigh… Well, since Inaros fought bravely, Artaxerxes magnanimously allowed him to live in Susa with a pension. If this is how we treat even our enemies, you may not worry about yourself. We will give you a prominent place in court and unlimited wealth. Unlike Vishvakarma, your name will be attached to your creation, and proudly recorded in History.'

'What if I refuse?'

'Then, hope the Seven will have mercy on you.'

Gargi took time to think, and Marduka patiently waited. As with Vassakara she felt forced to choose one of two paths she hated equally, and she was determine to create a third path of her own.

'Will you grant me a loan?' she finally asked.

Marduka was taken aback. 'Princess Gargi, I must have explained myself wrong. We will give you more money than you can count, without you having to repay a single silver.'

'No, I will pay you back every silver you give me. In return, everything I create will be mine.'

'It will be yours anyway, princess.'

'Not if the empire pays for it.'

Marduka struck his beard, dumbfounded. ‘You would be taking an immense risk, Gargi. You will have to manage everything yourself, and if you fail to deliver… we will have to deport you.’
‘I will not repeat Vishvakarma’s mistake.’

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Gargi received an order for eighteen computers, to be delivered within two months. She rented a room in Marduka’s mansion to sleep, as well as a parcel of his gardens to house her workshop. With Artaxerxes’ accord, she was given freedom inside Susa, but forbidden to leave the city. Her loan was significant, but it melted away much faster than she expected. First, she had to hire carpenters to build her single-room workshop. Then, she had to obtain paper, ink, wires, cogs, battery chemicals… It took her an entire week to find all the necessary suppliers. Most of them inflated their prices for her, claiming that, as a woman without entrepreneurial experience, she risked failing to pay them. She wished to hire a worker, but she didn’t speak Persian and the Susan lower class didn’t speak Aramaic. She eventually found an Aramaic-speaking boy named Gideon, thrown into poverty after his father disappeared, but he demanded one holiday per week, citing a commandment from his god. After the first month ended, Gargi still hadn’t completed a single prototype. Many times, she regretted refusing Marduka’s offer, but she remembered Vishvakarma’s last lesson. She made a million mistakes, knowing she had nobody but herself to blame, yet she kept going, knowing that success would be hers as well.

One evening, two weeks before the dreaded deadline, Gargi was sitting at her desk wanting to throw away her tools and scream. As Gideon was in the workshop with her, she composed herself. After sleepless days and nights spent trying to design the system for processing programs, it kept failing. She felt as if a nefarious bug was crawling inside the machine, ruining her attempts every time. Rain fell heavily upon the wooden roof of the cabin. Unexpectedly, the door swung open, and she saw a pair of yantra eyes shining from outside. Gargi clutched her stylus like a knife. Heavy steps shook the cabin floor, and now the eyes were looking down at her. They were blue, not red. The bulky machine placed a basket of food on her desk and stepped back with creaking movements. It had nothing of the silent elegance of yantras.
‘I was told you haven’t left this place in two days,’ a voice said, ‘so I thought you must be hungry.’
A young man appeared. He wore a white linen robe with a thick blue sash around his waist.
‘What is this?’ Gargi asked.
‘This is my proudest creation! I named it *Golem*. What do you think of it?’
He put his hand on the Golem’s neckless head as if introducing a close friend, and smiled at her, expecting a compliment.
‘Thank you for the food,’ she said addressing the Golem.
‘If it could talk,’ the young man replied, ‘it would say you are welcome.’
‘Does it recognize human language?’
‘No, I never knew how to program something so complex. When I need it to perform a task, I put the instructions directly in its mouth. I love mechanics but I don’t like programming.’
‘Well…’ Gargi sighed. ‘I am the opposite.’
‘Programming feels inhuman to me. Don’t you feel that way, too? It is language stripped of any poetry, nuance and humor. Language fit for obedience. It’d even say it’s ungodly, since even the word of God is open to interpretation!’
Gargi opened her mouth but didn’t know how to respond. She had been so focused on her work that her mind abstracted anything else as undesirable.
‘Oh, sorry,’ he exclaimed, ‘it was rude of me not to introduce myself! You can call me Yeshua. I am a Kohen, which I believe is similar to your Brahmins.’
Hearing that title irritated Gargi. ‘Why does a priest build machines?’
Yeshua chuckled. ‘You sound like my fellow Kohens. They think it’s beneath us, but if we are created in the image of God, then making our own creation must also be sacred, don’t you think?’
‘What are you doing here?’
‘My caravan just arrived and Marduka is accommodating us here in his gardens – the parts you are not renting, of course. I apologize in advance for any disturbance we may cause. I will lead the prayers indoors so we won’t bother you.’

Gargi's heart was racing and she hated it.
'Alright,' she said coldly. 'Now will you please excuse me? I need to get back to work. Thank you again for the food.'
'Are you thanking me, this time?'
'You could have carried it yourself. It doesn't look that heavy.'
'But I wanted you to see my—Oh, is that a processor you are making?' His head tilted to the side. 'It looks odd. I doubt you'll get it to work like that. If you want I can—'
'I need no help. Please leave me alone!'
Yeshua bowed slightly and left with his Golem. Gargi put the basket aside to focus again on her cogs and wire, but she must have lost consciousness shortly after, for the next thing she remembered was Gideon shaking her by the shoulder. He invited her to share the food with him.
'What an impertinent brat, this one!' she suddenly exclaimed after they started eating. 'A priest making machines – and he doesn't even know how to train them to recognize human language! Without us, those priests can't make yantras. They *need* us. The Brahmins took power only because we gave it to them…'
Gideon watched her like she was a madwoman. Gargi sighed.
'Gideon, what does it mean that we are created in the image of the gods?'
'You should ask Yeshua.'
The reverence in his voice gave Gargi pause.
'Tell me, Gideon, if we create machines in our image, are we like gods to them? If the gods created humans in their image, are we like machines to the gods?'
'I do not understand what you say, princess. Maybe you should sleep.'
'Nay, I'll just rest a little…'
Gargi laid down on the bare floor to rest, and inadvertently fell asleep. Gideon went to the neighboring Judean caravan's camp to borrow a cushion and a blanket for the princess, then returned home. Both of them slept well into the following afternoon.

Chapter 13

As Gargi slowly opened her eyes, still floating in a dreamy realm. She wondered where she was without caring for the answer, until her deadline, forgotten for a blissful moment, burst back into her awareness. She leapt up and sat back at her desk, facing her failing prototype again, but her eyelids felt heavy against the effort. 'If you won't succeed anyway', a voice crept in her head, 'why exhaust yourself?' She dropped her tools and leaned back. 'Why bother?' the voice pressed on. She didn't have the heart to retort anything to that voice. Then, she noticed the pillow and blanket on the floor and frowned, imagining that silly priest – what was his name again? – daring to lift her sleepy head to place the pillow underneath… She kept brooding until, in a spark of lucidity, she realized how silly she was. She stood, picked up the cushion and blanket, and left the workshop. The garden was filled with blue tents up to her doorstep. She looked around. At this hour of the afternoon, the camp was mostly empty, but thankfully she spotted Yeshua.
'Gargi!', he exclaimed as she approached. 'Have you slept well? You certainly look like you have.'
The princess blushed, suddenly becoming embarrassed by her ruffled hair and wrinkled clothes. She handed him the pillow and blanket. That made him laugh.
'Why are you laughing?' she asked vexedly.
'Well, I have spent the last few hours packing gifts for the queen of queens: scrolls, jewels, myrrh… and here you give me this! The contrast made me laugh.'
'Are you meeting the queen?'
'Yes. She is honoring me with a dinner invitation. Immortals should arrive in a moment to escort me to the citadel. Of course, in addition to the precious gifts, I will give her my blessing as a Kohen. After all, giving her this blessing is the reason that finally convinced my grandfather to let me join this caravan.'
Gargi resisted the temptation to ask him who his grandfather or why the queen wanted a blessing from a foreign priest.
'Yeshua, perhaps this is not the right time to talk about it, but I would like to make a deal with you. You are good with hardware. Please help me build processors for my computers; in return, I will teach you how to make your Golem intelligent.'

‘Sorry, dear Gargi, I am not sure this is a good idea.’
A servant announced from the garden entrance that the Immortals had arrived. Yeshua went inside his tent, deposited the cushion and blanket, and came out followed by his Golem. It was carrying a silk bag on its back, while its hands were holding a beige boulder.
‘Now I must go,’ Yeshua said. ‘Let us resume our conversation tomorrow.’
‘Alright, but will you spare a princess the torment of unanswered questions, by answering one?’
Yeshua smiled and peered up into the cloudy sky. ‘Aren’t our whole lives spent tormented with questions we cannot answer?’
‘I am sure you can at least answer this one: if you already use your Golem to carry heavy loads, don’t you want it to be able to perform finer tasks?’
‘Tasks like praying or composing psalms? I don’t think so. If I delegate the actions that give my life meaning to the Golem, then these actions won’t be mine anymore.’
‘Exactly!’
Gargi had cried this out involuntarily, and realized the voice came from her twelve-year-old self.
‘If my actions are not mine,’ he continued, ‘that means I’m a puppet – the puppet of the very machine supposed to be at my orders! And by losing my freedom, I lose my humanity as well, because free will is what sets us apart from other creatures. If God thought obedience were enough, He’d have made only animals and angels.’
The young priest excused himself and went. Gargi was so busy pondering his words that she forgot to say goodbye. Finally, the questions she had been asking in a void for years had found an echo. She still wasn’t sure to understand what this concept of freedom meant, but she was sure she wouldn’t give it up either.

That evening, she walked around the streets of Susa, its pavements wet and slippery from the rain of yesterday. Her deadline was now one day closer, without her having done any progress, yet her heart was pacing with impatience rather than dread. When she returned to her workshop, Gideon was here, still working on the writing feature. She looked for the basket of food, but to her disappointment Gideon had finished it in her absence. She had been eager to eat the few sweet Judean dates left. If Yeshua wouldn’t accept her deal, she thought, at least she could ask him for more of these dates.

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After Gargi read the piece of papyrus Yeshua handed her, she erupted with anger.
‘I am not signing this! I won’t give away one tenth… or one hundredth of it!’
‘Well, am I not forcing you to. If you feel confident that you will deliver your order in time, don’t sign it.’
Gargi was fidgeting with the sheet, wanting to tear it apart. ‘Give me a few days, and you’ll see.’
‘Even if you manage to make your processors work in a few days, you won’t finish the assembly and testing in time.’
‘Then so be it. This enterprise is *mine*.’
‘Even if you give me a tenth, it will still be yours.’
‘Aren’t you a hypocrite, Yeshua? Yesterday you told me that if you stop owning your actions, you lose your freedom. My master said something similar. But now you want to take ownership away from me, like my freedom is a food basket you can pick from.’
‘Why can’t I own my processors, if you own everything you invented? Do you only care about your own freedom and not that of others?’
Gargi looked away, as if Vishvakarma stood in that direction ready to give her much-needed advice. She picked up her stylus.
‘Why should I trust you?’ she asked.
‘You don’t need to trust me. If this enterprise is mine as well, I better do my best to make it work. Also, it is clearly stated in the contract that the tenth only go to me once I’ve made successful processors.’
The princess thought for a moment. Yeshua’s confidence was hard to resist. She dipped the stylus in the ink and signed her name in both Sanskrit and Aramaic letters. Yeshua immediately sat next to Gargi and, after hours that felt like instants working together, the prototype processed its first program successfully. Gargi wanted to keep incrementing, but Yeshua pointed out that without taking

time to celebrate and rest, they wouldn't have the energy to keep going very long.
'Gideon, would you please get us something to eat at the bazaar? Here, you can spend this whole silver. Be careful not to buy anything with beef!'
'Will you come with me?' Gideon asked gravely.
'We had such an intense session, I think we'll be resting here.'
'It is impure for you to be alone with a foreign woman.'
'Am I not also a foreigner here? But fine, we'll go with you.'

Halfway to the bazaar, at the top of a steep alley, Yeshua stopped and turned around, inviting Gargi and Gideon to do the same. From this high point the citadel stood both close enough to be admired in its refined ornaments, and aloof enough to awe with complete majesty. The sun, setting behind its crenels, completed the picture with its halo.
'This is my favorite view in the city,' Yeshua explained.
'I can understand,' Gargi replied. 'I think it just became mine also.'
They kept watching, letting the evening wind whisper around them.
'I feel like we are conquerors about to take that fort,' she added.
'Be careful, princess,' Gideon said. 'They might hear you.'
She shivered and turned away. As they went on, she wondered from which Gargi the imprudent remark had come – the builder or the Kshatriya – and whether both identities were fighting inside her.
'Tell me, Gargi, if you were queen, what would you do differently from other rulers?' Yeshua asked.
'I'm already busy enough building those eighteen computers! I wish I could ask my father how he managed to rule millions and still find time… find time to play with me.'
The princess's throat tightened, trying to keep the grief she had buried under all her hard work from resurfacing. Yeshua diverted the conversation.
'Once you've completed your order, I hope they'll allow you to leave Susa. If you'd like, I can speak to…'
'Thank you, but I don't think mere words would weigh anything against the interest of empires. For now, I am worried not being allowed to stay, more than to leave.'
'I wish you'll be able to explore the world soon.'
Gargi smiled, understanding what he really was thinking about.
'At worst,' she said, 'you'll have to come to Susa again.'
'It's already miraculous that I convinced my grandfather, the High Priest, to let me travel this time. He wants me serving at the Temple.'
They descended the hill side by side, carefully minding the unequal pavement, and feeling confined within themselves.
'Ah, Gargi, why can't someone decide to become a priest, or a warrior, or a merchant without needing to be born into the right family?'
'Don't you think there are good reasons for castes?'
'How can you possibly think so? To me, the powerful only established castes to guarantee that their children, grandchildren, great-grandchildren and so on will have their elite position secure for all time.'
'If such was their only motive, then why did they create separate castes for priests and princes? Perhaps our forefathers knew that if someone were to hold both spiritual and temporal power, that would give them absolute power. With castes, at least, power is checked and balanced, because princes cannot rule without the license of priests, and priests cannot pray without the protection of princes. If you want to know what happens when the caste system vanishes, look at Magadha…'
As she was saying this, her nostrils were tickled by the holy smell of incense mixed with the profane smell of grilled meat. The street they were passing had a fire temple on one side, and a casern on the other. The covered bazaar started a few yards ahead. Yeshua stopped before they'd step into the noise.
'What is really happening in Magadha? Ask anyone here, and they'll tell you the yantra empire is paradise where everybody lives like a king. I want to know the truth.'
As she told the truth to Yeshua and Gideon, she had to pause many times to keep her emotions controlled.
'I feel like a coward for being here,' she concluded. 'I should be in Magadha, fighting to liberate my

people.'
'Even if you could,' Yeshua replied, 'it is not your responsibility.'
'Then whose is it?'
'The people. They surrendered their freedom, didn't they?'
'How could they know? They didn't even have a choice! Before the yantras, the people had tremendous power, because without them, there would be no food and no army, but once the yantras replaced them – why would their rights matter anymore? Someone needs to do stand up to this regime, but… who else can it be but me?'
Gideon looked towards the bazaar, then back at Gargi.
'Princess, I thought we had come here to buy food.'
'And to celebrate!' Yeshua added. 'We've just achieved a major breakthrough – why are we standing here talking about shames and apprehensions? Come on!'
Gargi decided to smile, and the three of them went under the bazaar's canopy. The crowd was quite dense at this time of evening, and after lingering too long in front of one food stand, Gargi lost sight of her friends. She started elbowing her way forward to find them. A market boy started following her, and pressed her to come to his shop. She ignored him. Then the boy mentioned that Yeshua and Gideon were already there. Before she was done asking how he knew them, they were already standing in front of his shop, full of objects made of carved wood. A strong hand grabbed her forearm and pulled her into the backroom. After her eyes adapted to the darkness, she found herself sitting alone across from a man whose copper skin bore many scars.
'It was time I spoke to you, princess' the man said. 'The king of kings has ears everywhere, but here he won't hear us.'
Gargi stood up but stopped before running away. Although this man looked only a few years older than her, something in him reminded her of her father.
'You are free to go,' he said. 'I won't run after you. In fact, I lost the ability to run on the day that an Immortal stabbed through my thigh. Of course, Artaxerxes took credit of that deed for himself.'
Gargi frowned. 'Will you listen to a fellow exiled prince?'
The princess sat back down. She noticed the cane on the man's lap.
'I am listening,' she said.
'My name is Inaros of Egypt. I attempted to free my country from the Persians. After my initial victories, many hailed me as a hero for revolting against such a vast and powerful empire, but now the same people call me a madman because I failed. I came close to defeating Persia, closer than anybody ever has… And I assure you, one day, this empire will outstretch itself and fall. Unless… You may surmise why I must talk to you.'
'Are you…' Gargi narrowed her eyes. 'Is this a test of my loyalty?'
'It is not. You do not have to say anything, but you must listen to what I will say next. If you provide Persia with yantras, it will never be defeated. My Egypt will remain in chains, and so will countless other lands, including the one your friend Yeshua came from. And need I mention the threat to your own country? You are from the stock of kings, Gargi of Magadha. You are not meant to provide machines to rival realms.'
'I am not building yantras, only simple computers.'
'This is already a boon to the empire. You must stop now before Persia grows too strong.'
'If I stop, I will be deported to my death.'
'Surely Marduka missed to tell you that, according to Persian law, under no circumstance can a woman can be taken away from her husband. If you marry in Susa, they will not be able to deport you.'
'But who would I—'
Gargi guessed the answer, and frowned. Inaros raised his chin.
'I am the blood of the gods, and once the Persian empire collapses – hopefully during our lifetime – an alliance between our two countries will mean boundless prosperity, since Egypt is the gateway to maritime trade with India. We'll create a world where trade has made war obsolete. Using your technology, we will dig a canal to link the Red Sea to the…'
They heard a peculiar knock.
'I wish we had more time to talk, Gargi of Magadha. Now go before your friends alert the Immortals of your disappearance. And think about what I said.'

Chapter 14

Summer had settled on Susa like a hen brooding over its nest. Yeshua had installed a few mechanical fans for the workers, but their breeze dissipated into the vastness of the room. The Golem stood at the entrance, and though its presence scared intruders away, it also attracted people's curiosity and fascination. It was rumored that the Magadhi princess had bought this abandoned storehouse to store a fabulous treasure. Everyone wanted a glimpse of the gold, the diamonds and the rubies, or at the princess herself. Some claimed she was leveling the storehouse to raise her magnificent palace on its foundations. But the workers, men from Yeshua's caravan, were here to restore the place. Gargi paid them extra to work in the heat, impatient to get her very own factory running. She was spending half her earnings from the eighteen computers for this renovation, but she knew every business in Susa would bid high for her next batch of computers. In the middle of the soon-to-be factory, sitting on a carpet among blueprints, Gargi and Yeshua were designing the machines to go along the assembly line. From the noises of hammering and sawing, they heard that of a cane hitting the bare floor. They stood up as the scarred man limped towards them.

'How did you get past the Golem?' Yeshua asked.

Inaros lifted his cane off the floor to stand on his two legs.

'I am still a warrior. And I advise you to address royalty with more respect.'

'What respect do I owe a failed Pharaoh?'

'Yeshua, please leave him,' Gargi intervened.

After Yeshua had reluctantly stepped away, Inaros looked around at the workers.

'They say you are building a palace here. It doesn't look like it.'

'I know. But any other solution… wouldn't be mine.'

'Do you think it will remain yours for long?'

Gargi answered nothing. When Gideon arrived at the princess's side, hammer in hand to drive the intruder away, Inaros had already turned to leave. Gargi sat back down, but struggled to focus on work. *Do you think it will remain yours for long?* Yeshua was telling her about flexible assembly lines, to anticipate making all sorts of useful machines beyond computers, but his voice betrayed that the Egyptian prince's visit had also troubled him.

'Tell me, Yeshua,' Gargi said. 'Is it right, what I'm doing? I build machines to live, and because I love it, but I might be dooming myself, and everybody else.'

Yeshua did not answer at once, his eyes lowering to the blueprints around them.

'Gargi,' he finally said, 'when I see you working here in this factory, I feel like I'm seeing a lioness hunting its prey… Well, sorry, perhaps the metaphor is a bit rude, but—'

'No, I understand what you mean. Like a fish swimming or an eagle flying?'

'That last one suits you best! You are where you are meant to be, doing what you are meant to do. How can it be wrong?'

'Your answer is in your own lioness metaphor: if a lion was roaming the streets of Susa eating passersby, it would be doing what it is meant to do – hunting – but that's no reason to let it continue!'

'A lion belongs in the wild, not in the city streets.'

'And I belong in Magadha, not here. Don't you think what we do is dangerous?'

'Tell me truly, Gargi: to whom have you ever done any harm?'

Gargi blushed. The renovation sounds dimmed, as workers started hitting nails or sawing wood more softly, trying to overhear what she would reply. She hesitated to answer, but knew that there would always be someone eavesdropping, as the Judeans made sure never to leave her alone with their Kohen. This was the price the had to bear for Yeshua's company. In a low voice, she recounted the incident of the king committing suicide over her pirated yantras.

'You are such a sweet soul for blaming yourself – but don't. If this king chose to be offended by a machine, it was his choice, and so was ending his life over it.'

'I disagree. If I hadn't pirated those yantras, he would still be alive. I followed my inclination to solve a programming challenge, making the first virus, and that ended in tragedy. Now I'm following my inclination again, and…'

'And you fear it will lead to another tragedy? Gargi, please, you sound like you have a curse. I don't believe in curses. Let's say you closed this factory today, and stopped making machines forever: then it might take ten, a hundred or a thousand years, but another great mind will rise and rediscover the science of machine-making. And I can't promise you that this future great mind will have as much

scruples as you.'
'No, Yeshua, you didn't understand me. It's not that I'm cursed, it's that… How to explain? A Kshatriya is not meant to do what I do!'
Gargi had expected Yeshua to retort, but instead he leaned back on the carpet, resting on his elbows and contemplating the high ceiling. The workers grew noisy again, and the dust made it hard to breathe. Gargi thought of ending the conversation to go back to her blueprints, but Yeshua eventually sat back up with an air of certainty.
'Finally, I understand,' he said. 'You always talk about your place in the world: that you are a princess, a Kshatriya… You are seeing your life not as a unique destiny you have to pave for yourself, but as a role you must play well – and bad things will happen if you don't. Isn't it so?'
'I do forge my own destiny. We all do. But at the same time, don't you think that we have a responsibility to keep the world from falling apart?'
'*To keep the world from falling apart…*' Yeshua repeated pensively. 'I think I found the fundamental difference between our two cultures. Where I come from, good is about *healing the world;* where you come from, good is about *preserving the world*. This is why you think that, by breaking away from the path others have laid for you, you'll sow chaos like an actor improvising in a scripted play. Then let me tell you that instead, you might be improving the show.'
Gargi thought for a moment. 'All I see that the world was only made worse by people who thought they knew how to improve it. People like Ravana… or myself. I don't want to keep making computers claiming to improve people's lives when I might just ruin them. *Healing the world* sounds beautiful, but sometimes what we believe to be the cure is actually poison.'
'Is it true that in India, there is a sect where people always walk with a broom and sweep the path in front of them to avoid crushing any insects? Even with such precaution, I'm sure they still accidentally kill some insects. Whatever we do, we might cause harm. But if we do nothing, we can't do any good either.'
'But I can do good in others ways than making machines.'
'As I already told you, Gargi, progress is inevitable. If you don't make machines, somebody else eventually will. So better it be you.'
'Tell me, Yeshua, if you were told to murder an innocent and that, if you refuse, someone else will do it in your stead – would you commit murder?'
'The only way innovation is similar to murder is that once it happens, there is no going back. The real question is how we handle what comes next. Intelligence is how we create new tools, and wisdom is how we use them. What we need isn't less intelligence, but more wisdom.'
'That's easier said than done. The Seven were supposed to teach the people how to live with yantras, and they failed.'
'If you want to defeat the Seven, then show the world that there is a better way.'
Gargi stood up from the carpet and looked around at the storehouse-turning-factory. 'I will try, but if I see my work doing harm – I'll destroy it all.'
Yeshua chuckled. 'Now these are the words of a true Kshatriya!'

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Workers lined up the whole length of the street to find employment at the factory. Some came for the prestige of building the most advanced machines in the empire, while others believed computers allowed predicting the future or talking to the dead. Gargi had feared receiving too few candidates, but having to sort through so many was a nightmare of its own. Thankfully, while she was busy recruiting, Gideon took care of integrating new workers and setting up the production line; he proved an effective manager, and reminded Gargi of that boy Gupta who used to sell her black-market material: a taciturn facade hiding a great depth of character. When she visited suppliers, Gargi was pleasantly surprised to find they were offering her lower prices than before, as her reputation was now proven. Her fame also attracted woes. Her workers organized a strike to demand higher wages, still believing the rumor about the treasure. She had to open her vault in front of them to show her funds were actually quite meager. Fortunately, orders for computers kept pouring in, filling the vault. Yeshua came almost every day to the factory. Although he never mentioned it, Gargi knew that he gave away his share of the profits to charity. Aside from helping with the heavy machinery, he also wrote vivid pamphlets to promote Gargi's computers across the city and beyond. With time, the

computer factory workers started seeing themselves as lords among workers, well paid and respected even by men of higher castes. In the streets of Susa, if someone saw the princess, they would tell it to their friends.

After a few weeks that passed both like seconds and like years, a score of servants from the Citadel arrived at the factory. As Gargi and Yeshua were away to visit a supplier, it was Gideon who welcomed them. They announced that the queen of queens was visiting the factory the next day, and they were coming to clean it first. They then hurried Gideon to go find Gargi and tell her of the visit. The boy was about to leave when an uneasy feeling gave him pause. He observed the servants starting to clean zealously, even touching the running machinery, causing frustrated grunts from the disturbed workers. Why didn't they order the factory closed until the queen's visit? Gideon decided to ring the bell, and send the workers home. The servants told him it wasn't necessary, and that the queen did not wish to cost the factory productive time, but this objection only confirmed his suspicions. Under the pretense of helping with the cleaning, Gideon gathered all of Gargi's documents to locked them inside the safe that Yeshua had made for her office. Only then did he run to inform the princess.

When the queen stepped inside the factory, Gargi and Yeshua were already bowing deeply to welcome her.
'I find the factory closed,' she remarked. 'I was hoping to see those brave workers in action.'
Gargi raised her head. She had heard of the queen's fabled beauty, and now she could see it for herself. Before lowering her eyes, as etiquette required, she noticed a slight resemblance in her traits with Yeshua.
'Your majesty,' the princess said, 'I was concerned that the noise would inconvenience you.'
'Not at all. Now, will you please guide me through all this impressive machinery?'
While Gargi was explaining how computers were assembled, she felt as if the queen was listening out of politeness more than interest. When Yeshua started explaining one of the machines himself, the queen made it understood, in her silent way, that she wished to hear only from Gargi. At the end of the tour, she lay a hand on the princess's shoulder.
'I thank you for your precious time, Gargi of Magadha. I must say that I am greatly impressed. I came from humble origins, while you are the daughter of a great king. Yet here I am visiting you from the citadel, and here you are showing me machines you've built with your own hands. Doesn't God have irony?'
Not knowing what to reply, Gargi turned to Yeshua, but the priest only pursed his lips.
'I was born and raised in Susa,' the queen went on, 'but you came from far away. Don't you long for home?'
'I…' Gargi shivered. 'I am quite happy with my life in Susa, your majesty.'
'I am glad to hear it, but I am still heartbroken that you were forced into exile. I will find a solution to enable you to return home whenever you wish.'
'This will not be necessary, your majesty. My home is here.'
'It is the least I can do for you.'
The queen stepped away towards the exit, her Immortals forming two lines around her. She turned back to the princess.
'You have contributed so much to our society. My husband and I are most grateful.'
'Your gratitude is more honor than I deserve.'
'One day, you may decide that you deserve more.'
Gargi froze. The queen did not wait for a response, and departed. Long after she left, the weight of her presence still rested on Gargi's shoulders. She sat in her office, panting. Yeshua came and might have said something, but Gargi ignored him. He decided to leave her alone.

The next day, under the noise of the restarted factory, Yeshua found Gargi sitting in her office, and wondered if she had not been moving since yesterday.
'I don't want to talk to you,' she finally told him.
'What could I have told the queen?'
'Anything to defend me. Doesn't she respect you? Why did you say nothing?'
'The queen knows that her beauty will fade, while your fortune will keep rising. She is lowborn,

while you are royalty, and building your own little empire under her nose. If I were to come to your defense, with the status I have, she'd see you as even more of threat.'
'What an excuse! If you left me to face her all alone, it's because you're a coward.'
Yeshua lowered his eyes, accepting the insult.
'I have a whole moon left in Susa,' he finally said. 'I can arrange to see the queen again before I go.'
'I don't need your help.'
Yeshua left her office and the factory to wander around the streets, thinking what Gargi could do. Perhaps she could formally renounce her title of princess, but the proud Kshatriya would never accept, and the queen would still feel threatened by her wealth and power. Perhaps she could get married—Yeshua shook his head and walked on. His steps brought him under the shadow of the citadel. The proud wall above him, with ancient stones seemingly too large to have been carried in the dawn of age, reminded him of the one supporting the Temple mount. His chest suddenly alighted with the confidence that, if he found the courage to speak to the queen, God would inspire him the right words. He went to the Immortals guarding the ramp to the citadel, and asked to speak to her majesty.

Chapter 15

Two days later, Yeshua entered the factory accompanied by his caravan leader and the Golem. Gargi had been worried about him. Now, seeing him, she understood. She dropped her papers and ran to him.
'Are you…'
'Yes, we've been ordered to leave Susa immediately. They say it's for safety concerns, but of course—I talked to the queen, and I thought she understood, but…'
'It's not your fault. You did something brave for me. Thank you.'
Yeshua looked around, uneasy.
'I don't want to leave you alone in this damn city.'
'Don't worry, I've survived worse.'
Gargi stepped to the Golem and caressed its bulky head.
'I'll miss *him*, too,' she said.
'You won't, because it's yours now. It will stay here and protect you.'
'But… don't you need it to protect you and your people?'
'Don't worry, we've survived worse.'
The caravan leader grunted impatiently.
'I don't know if we'll ever see each other again…' Yeshua hesitated. 'So I wanted you to know that… Where I come from, we say that *every life is worth a whole world*. You, Gargi, made me realize how much this is true.'
The eyes around them prevented them from saying goodbye the way their hearts wished. Still, Gargi grabbed Yeshua's hands and said, 'Thank you', meaning something else.
'You too', he replied to the something else.
After they parted, Gargi remained a long moment at the door, facing the empty street. She did not want Gideon and her workers to see that she cried, but they knew.

In the following weeks, Gargi continued to expand her production. Her only shield against the queen, she figured, was her indispensability. Although she was becoming the richest woman in the empire, she still slept in her office at the back of her factory. People often came to ask her how long it would still take her to create yantras like in Magadha, and she always responded evasively. Gideon proved talented with mechanics, helping Gargi improve her machines, but he was no replacement for Yeshua, especially not in conversation. In the crowd of workers, suppliers, clients and admirers, her soul sank into loneliness. She yearned for someone to talk with.

One day, on her way back from visiting an artisan complaining that his computer wasn't working properly, she noticed that in every street she crossed, scores of people were hurrying in the same direction. She decided to follow them, and found herself lost in a crowd under the walls of the citadel. All eyes were looking up. A woman carrying her child told her that an execution was about to take place, though she had no idea who was being executed. Between the crenels, a cross was raised.

The people cheered. Gargi did not. Even at this distance, she recognized the man being crucified. She turned away and ran back to her factory, shaken. If, after years of allowing him to live in Susa, they had decided to eliminate Inaros so publicly… After a sleepless night in her office, she left in the early morning and went to the citadel, asking to meet the king of kings.

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Gargi felt like a doll as she was being bathed, groomed, perfumed and dressed up in opulent sari and jewelry. When she was presented a mirror, she barely recognized herself. This was another Gargi, one who had remained a princess. When she stepped into the throne room, she knew there was no grander hall in the world. It took a great amount inner strength not to feel minuscule under its forest of high pillars topped with monstrous heads of bulls. Beyond these pillars, the king of kings Artaxerxes seemed rather small in this enormous space, but everybody else seemed smaller still. A cushion and rug had delicately been placed on the floor so that the princess could comfortably kneel and bow before the man who ruled half the known world. After she rose, she felt Artaxerxes's intense stare scanning her body. Surely, he had not forgotten that the woman now standing before him could have been his wife.
'Princess Gargi of Magadha, I know why you have come to me,' Artaxerxes declared. 'In fact, I now know you better than a lover.'
Artaxerxes was pleased to see Gargi shrinking despite herself.
'That rebel Inaros lived at my mercy, and died at my will' he went on. 'I crucify scums of his kind when it pleases me. Now, since you are already here, Gargi of Magadha, let us talk about a more important subject. *Yantras*.'
He paused to watch Gargi's reaction, but she didn't look as afraid as he hoped. He decided to fix that.
'When you arrived in Susa, you would rather have been deported than make yantras. Back then, you were but a ragged exiled. Now, you have thriving enterprise to your name, workers who depend on you, and grand plans for the future. Now, you have something to lose.'
Again, Gargi did not show signs of fear. She had anticipated such threats. When Inaros screamed above the city, she heard it as a warning to herself, and to every vassal in the empire. Artaxerxes was fearing rebellions sponsored by Magadha, and saw her as a liability more than an asset unless she produced yantras. She took a deep breath.
'Please, your majesty, I wish to be deported back to my dear homeland.'
The flicker in Artaxerxes's eyes betrayed that he had not expected this.
'You find me disappointed by your intelligence, princess. In your factory, you have blueprints, programs and work notes. Once you are deported, I can ask my scholars to study these documents and deduce all your secrets. We can build yantras without you.'
'I dare your majesty to try.'
Artaxerxes chuckled. He was pleased to discover that this princess was far more stubborn that he thought. Now, he knew, it was only a matter of a few years before his scholars unveiled to him machines as capable as the yantras and loyal only to him. He smiled at the princess.
'You may keep this dress and these jewels, princess Gargi of Magadha. Accept them as my farewell gift.'
He rose and ordered that the princess be escorted with honor by two-score Immortals directly from the citadel to the Indus river.

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The Immortals escorted her outside Susa but, as the sun was already setting, they made camp on a hill overlooking the city. While they raised the tents and prepared supper, Gargi stood against the evening wind, contemplating Susa for the last time. Then, she started fidgeting nervously. After sunset, she started hearing the sound of bells. The Immortals rushed to Gargi's side to see what was happening. A column of fire illuminated the night, rising from the location of the factory. Tears poured out of Gargi's eyes. They were tears of relief. Gideon had found the letter she had left on her desk before leaving to the citadel, with the key under it, and read her instructions. With the key, he had opened the vault to share her funds among the workers, letting them leave early. While they returned home with enough money to feed their families for a year, Gideon remained at the factory to

arrange the entire stock of batteries one next to another along the walls. Then, he stood at the entrance and waited. Night fell, and the princess still had not returned. He ignited the first battery. Fire spread to the next battery, and the next. The sound of approaching iron hooves shook the pavement, but before running away, Gideon took a moment to watch the flames swallow the factory, its machinery, its secrets and its Golem, as a last tribute to the princess and the priest.

Chapter 16

The Indus river murmured loudly along the rocky banks. Between the bare mountains on either sides of the valley, the sun was rising. A rowboat was being assembled by the Immortals to ferry the princess across. On the opposite bank, a Brahmin waited with a score of yantras and a horseless chariot. While their officer rowed Gargi to Magadha, the Immortals banged their spears on their shields as a salute. They knew what awaited her. When she stepped on the firm ground, the Brahmin greeted her laconically. He helped her come on the chariot in a manner that was brutish but not rude. As they winded through the mountains with amazing speed, Gargi looked straight in front of her, making a show of not appearing afraid.

‘I thought you’d recognize me,’ the Brahmin said after many miles.

In truth, she had already recognized him. She wondered was part of him was still a friend.

‘Gupta,’ she asked, ‘why did you become one of them?’

He let the wind fill the silence between them.

‘What happened to you?’ she insisted.

He turned icy eyes to her. ‘My answer, Gargi, is in your question.’

‘What do you mean?’

‘If you think it’s wrong that I, the lowborn servant, was permitted to rise according to my merit, then which one of us chose the right path?’

The chariot’s speed was dizzying her already, and now Gupta’s words made her head ache. She closed her eyes and massaged her forehead.

‘Look at the road in front of you, pr—Gargi, and the motion sickness will go away.’

‘Why won’t you call me *princess*, as you used to?’

‘There are no Kshatriyas anymore. Nor Brahmins. Now there are only two castes, relevant with our new world: the *Once-born*, and the *Twice-born*.’

‘And you are…’

‘I had a second birth, yes. Not long after you fled, Ravana paid a visit to my flat. My mother and I were scared at first, of course, but he wasn’t accompanied by yantras or anything. Just himself. He invited me at his house and took me as his novice.’

‘I suppose that he recruits those whom he deems intelligent and ambitious enough like you. It is a clever way to swallow opposition before it can threaten his oppressive regime.’

‘How is it oppressive?’

‘Gupta, I wanted to practice my passion, and you wanted to earn some money for your family – why did we have to hide?’ She sighed. ‘You once told me, Gupta, that you felt as if the gods had abandoned us. I felt it too. The world had become so immoral, so meaningless… Don’t you still feel it?’

Gupta grunted. ‘The gods I was referring to were mere projections we made on nature. Humanity could stand the idea of being at the mercy of an indifferent, unfeeling and unpredictable universe, so they attributed personas to the elements. This way, they felt that wildfires, storms or earthquakes could be appeased, or at least accepted as punishment for their sins. But now, we have tamed nature. Technology has replaced the gods as our buffer against the elements.’

‘You are talking about superstition, not divinity. When you make music, Gupta, don’t you feel like you are channeling energy from a higher source? Then you know there is something beyond ourselves! You can *feel* it. How can you say that gods are just… some kind of painkiller drug?’

‘The gods are illusions, but divinity is real. What I feel when making music, or what you feel when programming, is indeed divinity. We can elevate ourselves to higher spheres because after our physical birth, we had a second spiritual birth – we are *Twice-born*. But the majority of people never rise beyond their animal existence – they are *Once-born*.’

‘I disagree! Everyone you condescendingly call Once-born would reach their spiritual second birth if only you gave them a chance.’

‘I will let Ravana convince you otherwise.’
Gargi frowned. After a long silence, she started looking at Gupta up and down, causing the young man to blush.
‘Gupta,’ she said, ‘do you know how scared I was for you? I thought they’d killed you, or worse tortured you for confessions… But now, I don’t know how I feel seeing you again.’
‘Gargi, if you are not happy to see me, you are not my friend.’
Gargi and Gupta never exchanged another word for rest of the two-day journey to Pataliputra.

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Gupta dropped off Gargi at her house, which still bore her name. Inside, it had been equipped with latest-generation yantras. The food and bath were ready for her to take. She let herself be undressed, washed, dressed again, and served a meal. The food was tasteless in her mouth. She felt like she couldn’t tell good from bad anymore. Had Gupta chosen the right path? Could Ravana turn her to his side as well? She stood up half meal, and didn’t hear the yantras reminding her that she had not consumed enough nutritional value for her age and body weight. She was now eager to meet Ravana, and face an opponent who might prove stronger than her. She left the house and went the palace, not minding the yantras closely escorting her.

The smell shocked her first. As soon as she stepped inside the palace vestibule, Gargi’s nostrils were filled with the heavy fragrance that did not belong here – the same blend of bodies and kitchen spices that oozed from crowded residential complexes. Then she heard the sound that came with it, the simultaneous groans and laughter and distorted music from speakers. The finely sculpted reliefs still covered the walls of the deserted corridors like a travesty of royal majesty. She wondered if those thousands of families relocated here were even aware of the beauty and past glory around them. Did they ever realize that, where they were now sleeping, eating and slacking, the fate of nations was once decided? Gargi had believed the Seven would take the royal palace for themselves, but now she saw they had found a much surer way to erase kingship from Magadha.
Even though Ravana was not to be found here, Gargi kept on exploring her former home. She found the library filled with extra floors and rooms to accommodate as many families as possible. What had happened to the books was a mystery. The grand hall, with its gallery, was repurposed as an atrium, but nobody strolled there. When she reached the door of what had been her own quarters, she paused, hesitated, then pushed the pane. On the desk where she used to spend sleepless nights programming, a yantra was holding an infant child, breastfeeding it with its yantra teat. The parents were laying on what had been her bed, watching some kind of bright animated screen. When they noticed the princess walking in, they barely reacted, looking at her dully.
‘I am Gargi, daughter of Ajatashatru. This… used to be my room.’
Hearing this, the man kept watching the screen but the woman stood up. She was barely dressed, but this did not seem to embarrass her. She bowed her head, perhaps as a vestige from the old world.
‘Don’t you have your own living unit?’ the woman asked.
‘*Living unit?*’ Gargi repeated with horror. ‘They put you in living units, like yantras have *charging units*! They are treating you like soulless machines!’
‘What do you mean?’
‘You are a human being!’
‘So what?’
‘Your life is sacred. It’s worth so much more than… this…’
‘Than what?’
‘Silence!’ the man groaned. ‘I can’t hear it anymore!’
Gargi apologized and hurried to leave. She stopped at the next door. As she was about to open it, she bumped into a mess of blond hair.
‘Gargi! I felt it was you! Welcome back to Magadha.’
Gargi wondered whether Roxana’s smile had always looked so fake. Perhaps she was too naive to see it at the time. The blond princess had taken weight, and when she noticed the difference between their bodies, her smile faded.
‘Don’t you have anything to tell me?’ Roxana hissed.
‘Where is my brother?’

Udayin appeared behind his wife. He had grown obese.
‘Udayin!’ Gargi cried. ‘What hap—’
‘Oh no,’ Roxana cut her, ‘he doesn’t want to talk to you. You talked ill about me behind my back, to Ravana. You must apologize!’
Gargi was not ready for this encounter. She’d rather have met Ravana.
‘Let me talk to my brother! What did you do to him?’
‘My husband is very happy.’
Gargi clenched her fists. ‘My brother only has one life. Give it back to him!’
‘Did you just say he only has one life?’ Roxana chuckled. ‘You pose as a traditionalist, but you don’t even believe in reincarnation!’
‘I don’t care how how many lives he’ll be given – he must own the one he has.’
‘And you must apologize to me!’
At this moment a yantra arrived to inform Gargi she was being invited to Ravana’s home. She walked away, blood throbbing in her temples.

Ravana still lived in the house across from Gargi’s. It was a true mansion, no mere living unit, but without gilding or paint, just plain wood – a proper Brahmin abode. The only marker that its occupant had power was a guard yantra at the door. As Gargi looked down the avenue, she noticed that most of the other houses had been split into living units or demolished to build residential towers like columbaria for the living. The door opened, and her heart started racing. Then, she heard a feminine gasp.
‘Oh! It’s you!’ a girl’s voice exclaimed.
Gargi had no time to see who this girl was before she was jumped at and hugged.
‘Kanika!’ Ravana’s voice boomed from inside. ‘What manners are this? Let our guest be, and invite her inside.’
Kanika kept hugging Gargi so tightly the princess was worried for her spine, until Ravana appeared at the doorstep.
‘I beg you to forgive my daughter’s manners. Tea and sweets are waiting for you inside. Please feel at home, dear Gargi. I believe you had never visited us before, despite living so close. It was time we repaired this wrong.’
Gargi followed Ravana and sat across him around a appetizing pyramid of laddu sweets and the volutes steaming from tea cups. She felt like in a bad dream, moving without her own accord. Kanika sat with them and immediately pawed the top of the laddu pyramid, staring at Gargi with admiration as she ate. Her father instructed her to stay silent.
‘Help yourself, dear Gargi! You’ve just had a long journey. My daughter has been waiting for your return with more impatience than even I, so please don’t mind her attitude. I believe she will grow to become the greatest Twice-born among us. She is only sixteen, but has already ended her noviciate. Soon enough, she might become the first woman to sit on the Seven’s council.’
‘The first woman to…’ Gargi dully repeated.
‘You seem surprised, but of course women can be priests too – or anything they want. Long gone is the old world. Now that the rule of the muscles has been replaced by that of the mind, what reason is there for men and women not to enjoy full equality?’
Gargi sipped her tea in an automatic gesture, but her hand shook and she burned her lips.
‘I am not forgetting,’ Ravana went on, ‘that you were the first woman to break the chains of the old world. Your father barred you from programming, yet you never yielded. Now, no woman will ever face similar restrictions again.’
‘*You* barred me from programming. I had to go to the black market, and when you caught me, you put me under house arrest.’
‘Now, dear Gargi, why didn’t you ask me to provide you the programming material you needed, instead of buying it illegally?’
‘You would never have accepted to procure me programming material.’
‘Why do you believe so?’
‘Because I would have used it to pirate the yantras and attempt to topple your regime.’
‘I appreciate your honesty, but why did you want to topple a system where Magadha is governed by the most able minds, women are equal to men, and everyone is free to live the way they want? Is this what you call *oppressive*?’

‘What about the so-called Once-born? Are they free to live the way they want?’
Ravana smiled. ‘They *are* living the way they want.’
‘How can you say that?’
He stood up. Despite their teacups still being half-full, he invited Gargi to join him for a walk. Kanika was allowed to come along. The teenage girl hurried to grab as many sweets as her clothes could carry, and out they went along the deserted avenue.
‘Dear Gargi,’ Ravana said showing the tall apartment buildings around them, ‘I will go even further than to claim everyone is free: everyone is *happy*. It might be hard to imagine for you, because you find happiness in meaning, but they don’t. Lock down a wolf and it will strive to escape to the forest and hunt; keep a dog outside its master’s home, and it will crave safety and warm food. What one calls happiness, the other calls misery. Here, we are letting everyone live their happiest life – not what we think is happiness for them.’
‘They were never given a choice.’
‘Don’t you remember, in the streets of Susa, how people came to you asking when the yantras would finally arrive? They knew what they wanted, and so did our people.’
‘People in Persia believe that Magadha is paradise. They don’t know the truth.’
‘Yes, they do. They are not stupid. Picture the average family in Persia: a man coming home exhausted from backbreaking work, a woman worried about dearth, a child wounded from playing outside. Now, look at the average family in Magadha. The man spends his days relaxing with his favorite entertainment, the wife receives all the food she needs, and the child plays stimulating games from the safety of home. If you gave the Persian family the choice between both lifestyles, which one would they choose in your opinion?’
‘You are pretending as though there were only two options.’
‘Please enlighten me, dear Gargi – what would be a third option?’
‘Living a meaningful life, even in the empire of yantras.’
‘Have I said that, once in Magadha, they couldn’t look for meaning? Nothing is stopping them from living in a way that you would consider meaningful. But they’re not interested. To them, fulfillment comes at a cheaper price.’
‘They’ve never been taught to live meaningfully. They went directly from laboring to idling, without being taught what to do with all their newfound free time.’
‘Were you ever taught to live meaningfully, Gargi? Everybody now has access to the same lifestyle and comfort that were once only accessible to aristocrats like you. More than anyone else, you were susceptible to become a Once-born – like your brother – but you craved more out of life. No one told you to look for meaning. That desire came to you naturally.’
‘We all have this desire. It just needs to be sparked.’
‘When you were in the womb, did anyone teach you to come out head-first? No – it was a matter of instinct. Thus it was also instinct that kept you pushing, beyond the womb, towards higher spheres. This was your second birth. Most people, however, are content with their physical birth, and never seek a spiritual one.’
Gargi looked at Kanika. The girl started, excited to be included in the conversation, but Gargi did not talk to her.
‘Tell me, Ravana,’ Gargi said, ‘if your daughter hadn’t been a so-called Twice-born, would you have let her fall into a meaningless life?’
‘Who am I to tell my daughter how to live her life? She is free to live like them, if that’s her choice!’
‘You call this freedom?’
‘Why, yes! Freedom is making your own choices. If you decide to live an idle existence, that is your choice, and it must be respected.’
‘That’s not what freedom means. Freedom is ownership over your actions.’
‘Isn’t that the same as the ability to make your own choices?’
‘I… I have to think about it.’
Ravana turned around and they started walking back towards his house in silence. When they reached the door, Gargi remained a few steps behind, politely signaling she wouldn’t come back inside.
‘Dear Gargi, I truly enjoyed talking to you,’ Ravana said. ‘Now you must be aching to rest at home. If there is anything you need, please do not hesitate asking me.’
Gargi looked down, feeling defeated, until she suddenly looked up again with an air of challenge.
‘I would need programming material. You said that I didn’t need to buy it off the black market, but

ask you directly.'
'Of course! However, allocations are managed by a complex yantra called the *Allocator*, which takes in the data from every inhabitant of Magadha to calculate their exact needs. For example, given somebody's age, weight and health, it produces food rations containing the exact amount of nutrients they need. I am afraid you are not currently in the Allocator's database. Once you are registered, it will be able to produce and deliver programming material to you.'
'Then please register me to the Allocator.'
'I had been planning to discuss this with you tomorrow, but I see you are impatient. For you to be registered, you need to belong to a caste. Once-born or Twice-born. Which one do you choose?'
'Kshatriya.'
'She can take mine!' Kanika exclaimed. 'I can give her my programming material.'
'Don't be silly, Kanika! Gargi must be registered anyway, to get what she needs to live.'
'I can hunt my own food,' Gargi replied. 'I don't need to survive off rations.'
Ravana's polite smile faded. 'Hunting is punishable by death. So is refusing registration.'
'Is that what you call freedom?'
'Your freedom ends where the freedom of others begins. The Allocator is what enables everyone to be free. Free from want. Free from work. We all have a right to food, shelter and other necessities – so long as we respect the system that safeguards that right. Now go home and think. It's an easy choice, but I'll give you three days. In the meantime you can come and go freely.'
'And then, how will I die?'
'Yantras can deliver painless euthanasia – but I am sure you will make the right decision!'

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Gargi was pacing her garden, feeling like a bird in a large cage. Ravana had given her a choice, but it didn't feel like freedom. She sat on the beaten earth track that had once been her shooting range. Her target was gone, and she didn't have a bow anyway. She missed shooting. She craved it. She remembered the blissful peace of focusing on the target and the thrill of watching the arrow reach its mark. Yet a voice crept in her head: is an archer free, if she is forced to aim at a single target? Maybe she could find fulfillment without freedom after all… Gargi looked around at the yantras staring at her, capturing her every movements, and wondered which one would deliver her euthanasia on the third day. Three days, two options, one choice. Once-born or Twice-born. Perhaps she could identify as *Trice-born*, the third birth being the realization that one is in fact as human as every other. The idea made her chuckle without joy. Then she looked up to the sky, thinking of Vishvakarma. Surely the Seven mustn't have let him live long after he helped her escape. In her own way she had mourned her master in Susa, making her private factory his monument – and funeral pyre. But now she felt like she was failing him, because her life had fallen back into the hands of others. If her life couldn't be hers anymore, then at least there was one thing left for her to own… Gargi stood up, serene and resolute. An archer is free, she answered the voice, not because she can shoot any target, but because each shot is hers. In the rosary of her garden, there were no blooming roses in this period before monsoon, but many thorns. She ripped a thorn from its stalk, closed her fist around it and went to her room.

After laying on her bed and pulling the blanket over herself, she paused. Was this blanket a worthy shroud for a princess? A shiver crept up her spine. She pictured her exhausted mother on a wet bed, holding the precious little being she had just brought into the world. She remembered the pride of her father congratulating her for the first time on that evening in Kushinagar. She felt the passion of Vishvakarma dedicating some of his invaluable time to teach her his secrets. She heard the voice of Yeshua saying something clever but impatient for her to retort. In her twenty-one years she had been loved, but now there was nobody left to cry for her. She hesitated, but reminded herself she was a Kshatriya, unafraid in the face of death, even if no one would sing of it. She sank the thorn into her wrist. Her last thought was how warm her blood was.

Chapter 17

Her eyes opened, and she felt only cool wind, blowing south. *Agni, guide this warrior to the realm of*

his ancestors… She looked for her father. She couldn't see him. Maybe he wasn't there. Maybe this was not the realm of the ancestors. It was dark, with only the flicker of a lamp. A girl appeared over her, close enough that she could feel her warmth. She heard her voice. What was her name?
'Gargi! Oh Gargi, answer me!' said the girl.
Now she realized she was still lying down. Suddenly she felt like laughing.
'Gargi! Please, answer me!'
Kanika started shaking her, but Gargi didn't feel like moving. The girl kept calling her name until she burst into tears. Now Gargi started weeping as well.
'I'm happy I didn't come too late! Here, I brought you some sugared water… Can you lift your head just a little? Let me help you… Here you go! You lost so much blood… take it easy!'
'Thank… Thank you.'
Gargi found the strength to lift up her body. She had expected Ajatashatru to hand her a cup of Soma, but she drank the sugared water with gratitude.
'What were you—' Kanika interrupted herself. 'Well, I do know what you were thinking! I deactivated every yantra in this house and rushed here the moment I realized you might do it. As always, I was right!'
Gargi lifted her hand and noticed her wrist was bandaged.
'I disinfected it,' the girl said.
'Why? I mean… Thank you for saving my life, but you heard your father: in two days I'll be dead anyway.'
'Idiot Gargi! Why don't you just buy time registering as a Twice-born?'
'Kanika, I—'
'Oh, I know what you'll say already! And I agree with you. We don't need castes. I have a plan to end this nonsensical system. I waited for you to return to Magadha, so we could create a better world together. But first, have some rest. I'll come back in a little while.'
Gargi closed her eyes, and slept until Kanika shook her shoulder.
'Sorry to wake you up,' she said, 'but we must have time to talk before sunrise. How do you feel? Ah, I am relieved I came in time! I know that you've just met me, but I've been watching you for years. I see you as my big sister!'
Gargi cringed at that word, but Kanika sounded earnest. Something in her childish way to speak hinted at a deeper dimension.
'I wonder,' Kanika went on, 'who is the best programmer. You or me?'
'Surely, you are. I wouldn't know how to pirate these latest-generation yantras.'
'Actually, they're easier to pirate than the old models you infected years ago.'
'You talked about a plan to end your father's regime. Does it imply a virus?'
'I will explain. Can you sit?'
'Let me try… There, I'm listening to you.'
'Good. Sister, when you say that there can be no fulfillment living like a Once-born, you are right. My father is delusional. Of course these people aren't happy! We must liberate them. I made a virus that—'
Gargi gently put her hand on Kanika's forearm to interrupt her.
'I'm sorry, Kanika, but we can't simply deactivate the yantras. Millions will die from starvation and war.'
'Don't worry, my virus won't deactivate anything. It will only affect household yantras. Once enough of them catch it, they'll execute at once. The Once-born population is about a hundred million, but it won't take more than an hour to euthanize them all.'
'*What!*'
'Sister, just think about how beautiful the world will be after that.'
'After murdering a hundred million innocents?'
'They're not innocents. They are wasting the unfathomable chance to live in an abundant and peaceful era. If they can't appreciate it, we don't need their miserable lives anyway. In the old world, the more humans there were, the more we could grow food and protect ourselves. The yantras have reversed that. Now, we can thrive with a small population. Those parasites only pollute, take space, and waste resources… Oh my sweet Gargi, imagine Magadha without them! Imagine our beautiful and bountiful land shared between one million people only!'
'This is nonsense, Kanika! The world is vast enough for billions.'

‘But we’d be rats racing against billions in the gutter! Humans are not meant to be rats. Everyone deserves to be unique, special and significant.’
‘Everyone already is!’
‘Sister, be honest with me.’ Kanika pointed at the moonlit skyline outside the window. ‘Look at all those ugly towers that deface our beautiful city – do you sincerely believe that every bum jammed inside is special?’
Gargi closed her eyes. She tried to find logical arguments against this madness, but Kanika’s reasoning came from pure logic. Gargi used to think that using logic alone was the best way to take decisions, but now she understood why humans were also gifted with emotions and spirituality. She looked at Kanika in the eye.
‘Kanika,’ she said, ‘you are a priestess. Don’t you believe that life is sacred? Don’t those millions of souls have a purpose?’
‘They do, and I’m here to fulfill that purpose!’ Kanika lowered her voice, as one talks inside a sanctuary. ‘As you know, the ultimate goal of each soul is *liberation* from the endless cycle of reincarnations, to blissfully reunite with the Absolute. Liberation is normally accessible only to the Brahmins who become renunciant, however… if millions of souls died at once, without any available next incarnation, they would be liberated! As a priest, what greater feat can I accomplish than saving millions of souls at once?’
‘Isn’t liberation a choice? They must earn it.’
‘Didn’t you tell my father that *freedom is ownership over your actions*?’
‘Yes, exactly, so they must own their liberation.’
‘But once they are liberated, they won’t have a self anymore, so ownership becomes irrelevant.’
Gargi’s head started to spin. She lacked the strength to keep sitting, but resisted the urge to sink back into her bed and leave Kanika to her plan. She couldn’t think of anything to retort. Kanika kept talking.
‘Sister, in the world that we will create, there will be no castes and no forbidden unions. So once Magadha is cleansed from the Once-born, we can bring Yeshua here!’
‘What are you talking about?’
‘Oh, no need to blush with me! Don’t pretend that there was nothing between him and you – I read all the spy reports. I was so disappointed that you two never even dared to kiss! Don’t you want to be with him?’
Kanika’s large eyes shone with such earnestness that Gargi let herself be seduced by her vision. She imagined herself alone with Yeshua, working with him on a winged machine that could fly them across the sky. *Every life is worth a whole world.* She pictured yantras grabbing every man, every woman and every child to sink a needle through their necks. *We are all made in the image of the gods.* She found the strength to stand up.
‘Kanika,’ she said firmly, ‘without realizing it, you are only being the next logical step to your father’s philosophy. He turned people into livestock, so you play the role of the knacker leading them to the slaughterhouse. This is the reason your father is wrong: no matter how well-groomed or well-fed, farm animals are doomed all the same.’
‘If they are doomed, then it is mercy to liberate them. It will need to happen only once. Never again.’
‘Of course it will happen again! Once you’ve established murder as a tool for the greater good, your turn will come, Kanika. Perhaps you will be deemed too old, too special or not special enough. No one will be safe.’
Kanika lowered her eyes and for a too short instant, the princess thought she had talked her out of her plan.
‘For now the one who isn’t safe is you, sister,’ Kanika sighed. ‘I’ll worry about myself being euthanized when the time comes, but today it’s your life I want to save!’
Gargi sat back down next to Kanika and couldn’t resist taking her in her arms. This girl was an enemy, she knew, but also her only friend. For a long moment they remained enlaced in silence.
‘Dawn is almost here,’ Kanika finally said. ‘It won’t be long until they come to this house to check in on you.’ She stood up. ‘I’ll go now and activate my virus.’
‘Wait, Kanika! You are able to pirate any yantra, no?’
‘Almost all, yes. Since the latest-generation yantras have been programmed by other yantras, most are left with vulnerabilities we can exploit.’
‘Then I think there is something we can try.’

While Gargi explained her plan, striking at the heart of the system, Kanika started fidgeting, already thinking about how to execute it. But at the end, she shook her head.
‘No, sister, we can’t do that. You’re not accounting for the risk. It would endanger millions—’
She stopped in shocked realization. Then, she took Gargi’s hand.
‘Alright, we’ll create your virus. But if it doesn’t succeed within three days, I’ll go forward with mine.’

Chapter 18

At first, a few haggard silhouettes started wandering the avenue, looking around in confusion, wondering if they were alone in growing hungry. When they encountered others like them, they understood they weren’t alone. The word spread. From her rooftop, Gargi watched with awe as the living unit towers emptied into the streets, which soon overflew with a torrent of black-haired heads. Infants were crying in their mother’s arms, and young men were shouting their anger around, expecting someone to have solutions. The crowd naturally flowed towards the royal palace, as it would have in the old days, but there it only met more hungry people. Anger turned to panic. Suddenly, the crowd started pouring into the large avenue leading to the Buddha’s tomb. Someone must have told them where the Allocator was located. Gargi wondered whether freedom was at hand. She rushed to join them – but a four-armed yantra seized her, and she felt the sting of a needle in her neck.

Gargi awoke with Kanika shaking her. She was slumped on a cushion with the golden stupa stabbing the clouds overhead, and Ravana looking down at her with pleased eyes. They were on a stage at the entrance of the tomb, surrounded by the crowd filling the esplanade. Occasionally, some protesters threw stones at them, but any projectile was shot midair by the impenetrable wall of yantras at the foot of the stage. A young shaggy Twice-born ran up the stair leading from the tomb’s entrance to the platform.
‘It is done!’ he declared. ‘The Allocator is ready to be restarted.’
‘Excellent!’ Ravana replied.
Gargi stood up with Gupta’s help, and the other Twice-borns on the stage gathered around her.
‘As you heard, my dear Gargi,’ Ravana said, ‘the Allocator is about to restart. Have you made your choice?’
‘Did you… Did you bring me here to kill me in front of the crowd as an example?’
‘Why, not at all! I would never make a show out of you. However, I did want to show you the crowd. Look at them!’
Gargi was about to retort that this protest was the proof he was wrong, because the people had risen at last to demand their freedom – but something was off. She looked at Kanika, who was holding a sort of tablet, probably controlling the yantras below. Why wasn’t she chastised for having pirated the most vital organ of the regime?
‘This,’ Ravana said over the many thousands of shouting voices, ‘is the proof you are wrong, dear Gargi. Now listen to them.’
‘Why? How am I wrong?’
‘Be silent and listen to them.’
She listened. *Restart the Allocator! Give us our rations now! We are hungry!*
‘You heard it! The Once-born are demanding not freedom, but security. That is the difference between us and them.’ He paused to hear the chants once more. ‘You know, dear Gargi, I am grateful that you convinced Kanika to stop the Allocator. Once we restart it, the people will feel even more grateful for their rations; this stage is for me to deliver them the good news that the only vulnerability of the Allocator has been fixed, and it shall never again stop feeding them. It also demonstrates to you that these people choose to be dependent.’
‘Perhaps if you hadn’t treated them like infants all these years, they would know how to live without depending on your system!’
‘Most of them are old enough to remember life in the old world. They’ve known other options than dependence, yet dependence is what they’re choosing now.’
The crowd suddenly grew louder, and moved in an odd way. A round silhouette was advancing towards the stage, and people parted to let it through, cheering it on. Gargi gasped. When Udayin

reached the yantra barrier, the people of Magadha behind him started demanding that he be let onto the stage. Ravana sat on the cushion.
‘Eventually they’ll tire of howling,’ he said. ‘Once they do, I will deliver them my speech.’
‘That’s my brother down there!’ Gargi cried. ‘These people are demanding to hear their king, not you!’
‘Your brother is the king of bums if he’s any king! He’s simply come begging for food like all the others.’
Gargi instinctively turned to Kanika, feeling she could convince her father to let Udayin come, but the girl was contemplating the crowd, smiling. Her hands, holding the tablet, trembled with impatience at the picture of all these people being erased.
‘Ah, but perhaps I can put that fat waste to good use!’ Ravana declared. ‘Kanika, you may let him come onstage! And Gupta, bring me a food ration!’
Before Udayin was halfway up the steps, panting from the effort, Gargi had joined him. After a short embrace, Udayin gently pushed his sister aside and continued up the stairs. The people roared in joy when they spotted him. Before he could speak, Ravana came to him with a packaged ration box.
‘Here is for you, Udayin! The Allocator is now active again, and more efficient than ever. You shall —’
Udayin eagerly grabbed the ration, and threw it away. Such was the silence that even those at the very back of the esplanade heard the box crashing down upon a yantra’s head. Nobody knew what to think. For the first time, Gargi saw shock in Ravana’s eyes. Udayin turned to his people.
‘O great people of Magadha,’ he started, ‘I have come…’
His voice faltered. He looked down, then shook his head. Gargi guessed that he had memorized a speech written for him by a yantra, but now chose to improvise.
‘Look at me!’ he exclaimed. ‘I’m… Just rising those steps exhausted me. Do you remember my father, King Ajatashatru? He was a great warrior, but I…’ He briefly looked at Gargi to revive his confidence. ‘What have we done with our lives? I don’t care if we live an infinity of lives – if we keep making the same choices – if we don’t change our ways now – then we’ll waste them all! I was once a king, but now look at me! And look at all of you! The yantras did not do this to us – we did this to ourselves! We gave up control of our lives because it was comfortable, convenient, even pleasurable… but now we’re starving beggars!’
The people murmured. Very few were sure to understand. Then someone screamed something to the left, someone chanted something else to the right, and each patch of crowd picked up a different slogan. *We want our rations! Long live the king! Feed us now! Death to the Seven!* Udayin trembled, unsure what to do next. Ravana chuckled.
‘These fools! Even now, they keep begging for a savior. My dear Udayin, do you truly believe you are the man to save them?’
‘Do you?’ Udayin retorted.
Ravana took a few steps away from the deafening shouts to think more clearly. Gargi did not want to leave him the chance to take back control of the situation. She stepped forward to face the crowd.
‘Brave people of Magadha! Freedom isn’t allocated – it is seized. Under this stupa, the Allocator that used to feed you has left you starving, but this is your opportunity. The choice is in your hands: will you go back to surviving off rations, or take back your lives?’
The ground quaked under hundreds of thousands of angry feet. From the way Udayin looked at her, Gargi knew she had made a terrible mistake. Like a rogue wave people suddenly charged forward with such violence that the guard yantras, which until then simply stood as a impenetrable wall, started fighting back to resist the pressure. Blood was spilled. Men and women fell but new ones sprung over them to meet their doom in turn. Gargi stumbled back, aghast. She turned to Kanika.
‘You control those yantras, no? Can’t you stop this massacre?’
Before Kanika could answer, Ravana stepped towards his daughter.
‘Darling,’ he said, ‘these people deserve a more dignified end. You were right that the best fate for their soul is immediate liberation. Please go ahead and shoot the darts.’
Kanika looked at Gargi, then back at her father.
‘Father… these people… if they’re like Udayin, maybe there’s a chance for them.’
‘It’s too late, now. They are doomed anyway. Better we give them mercy.’
Kanika froze, unwilling to execute, but too afraid to disobey openly.
‘Kanika, what are you doing?’ he pressed her. ‘There is no other choice!’

‘Haven’t you heard our master?’ Gupta barked. ‘If you won’t do it, I will!’
Gupta grabbed the tablet to pull it away, but Kanika wouldn’t let go. Udayin and Gargi rushed to her aid. Others joined in on Gupta’s side. The undignified melee moved around the stage like a blind spider. Suddenly Kanika lost her grip, and Gupta snatched the tablet from her hands. Untethered from his own pulling force, he stumbled backwards and put his foot behind to keep his balance, not realizing he was already on the edge and stepping on emptiness. He fell to his death, breaking the tablet under him. The yantras deactivated, and the crowd gushed onward and into the stupa, crying for rations. Gargi hurried downstairs, but Kanika grabbed her forearm.
‘Sister, what are you doing?’
‘Leave me, Kanika! I have to save the ashes!’
Gargi continued, but Kanika hadn’t let go and they both fell into the human torrent. They were separated. People kept accumulating inside the stupa, but no one knew where to find access to the underground. The crowd grew so dense it squeezed the princess’ chest and choked her. She fought for every available inch of space and struggled to keep her face above the surface, taking too short breaths whenever possible. After an interminable moment somebody finally found the Buddha-yantra, and the weight of thousands broke it open. As the crowd flowed down to the underground, Gargi was released from the pressure and elbowed her way to the center of the tomb. Thankfully the urn was still there, intact behind the smashed panes. Gargi reached in, cutting herself bloody with the glass shards. Kanika had joined her on the altar, and for a moment they both stood there, looking over this cavernous room together in disbelief of what was happening. There was a smell of smoke, and scream of panic. The looters suddenly burst out of the underground entrance. Some were covered in flames and collapsed on the floor, ran over by others trying to escape. Power went out inside the stupa. A stampede followed as the flames started eating at the statues and the cupola.
‘Gargi! Do you hear me? We need to go!’
Kanika grabbed her hand that wasn’t holding the urn, and the two girls ran to the back of the tomb with enough speed to cut their way ahead. They left the stupa without being noticed and went around it to run through the esplanade and beyond, finally stopping at a famous guru school upon a hill outside the city. From the school’s steps, they saw columns of smoke rising from every neighborhood like the funeral pyres of the new world. Rain started pouring down, preventing the fire from spreading to the entire city. The golden stupa, however, became a giant torch that came crashing down. A mob climbed the metallic Shiva statue, tying ropes around it and pulling them to break it down; Gargi wondered whether the people meant to blaspheme or to reclaim their wealth. Kanika started weeping. When the princess attempted to comfort her with an arm over her shoulder, the girl turned it away.
‘When they find me,’ she said, ‘they’ll tear me apart. Just like this Shiva.’
‘No, they won’t. I’ll protect you.’
Kanika squeezed Gargi’s hand. ‘Don’t. I wanted to kill them all, so it’s only fair they kill me.’
‘They don’t have a right over your life, Kanika, in the same way you never had a right over theirs.’

After sunset, chaos seemed to ebb. The two friends kept sitting on the steps and holding hands until they heard approaching footsteps. Gargi leapt up. She wished she had her bow but never mind, she stood ready to face any attacker without flinching. She pressed Kanika to hide inside the school, but she refused. A thin silhouette emerged from the trees. His clothes were burned and shredded, but his body seemed unharmed.
‘Father!’
Kanika ran to her father’s arms.
‘I knew that if I would find the two of you alive,’ Ravana said, ‘it would be here. I am relieved to see you both unharmed.’
He turned to the lights of Pataliputra and sighed, worn and exhausted.
‘As for what will happen to the people, with no one to guide them… There will be chaos. As for me… perhaps I have failed… or perhaps people can’t be saved. Let someone else try… I am done. It is time for me to give up my responsibilities toward mankind, and become a renunciant.’

Epilogue

The chants from the orange-clad monks filled the brick cupola. Gargi came forward, carrying the urn

with her scarred hands. She had insisted on returning the ashes herself. At first, the monks had objected that she was too impure, but after she promised them a generous donation to build a monastery in Kushinagar, they yielded. Now, steps away from the altar, Gargi stopped abruptly. The memory of her father noticing her, hugging her, telling her that she made him proud for the first time – was she about to bury it? She shook her head and walked on. Perhaps the past deserves to be buried, she thought, as the seed for the future to grow. When she placed the urn back whence she had stolen it as a child, she felt healed. She knew this deed wouldn't change the world, but she had done it for herself. Stepping out of the dark stupa into the bright blue sky, an idea made her smile: being a small part of the world, by healing herself, she was also healing the world.

The monks had organized a communal meal after the ceremony, but the princess was not invited. Instead, she walked back alone to her inn, mingling with the dispersing crowd of spectators that had cheered her on her way to the stupa. A small Brahmin boy started pulling at her sari.
'Kautilya!' his mother cried. 'Leave the princess alone!'
Gargi gestured that she wasn't being bothered and knelt to the boy's height, curious to hear what he wanted.
'Princess, now that you have returned the ashes, will things go back to the way they were before?'
'I don't think so.'
'Then, what will happen?'
She smiled. 'What do *you* think will happen?'
'Why are you asking me?'
Gargi rose, looked at the people passing by, then back at the child.
'If not you, who else?'

THE END